

ATTITUDES AND ORAL PROFICIENCY IN HERITAGE SPEAKERS OF BRAZILIAN PORTUGUESE

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**ATTITUDES AND ORAL PROFICIENCY IN HERITAGE
SPEAKERS OF BRAZILIAN PORTUGUESE**

A Dissertation Presented

by

FLÁVIA TERRA CUNHA

Submitted to the Graduate School of the
University of Massachusetts Amherst in partial fulfillment
of the requirements for the degree of

DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY

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To my father.

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ABSTRACT

ATTITUDES AND ORAL PROFICIENCY IN HERITAGE SPEAKERS OF BRAZILIAN PORTUGUESE

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A Heritage Speaker (HS) has traditionally been defined as someone who grew up in a place where the language spoken by the general population (a.k.a. the dominant language) is different from the language spoken at home by their family (a.k.a. the heritage language). Though there are many variations on the definition of a HS, data from a variety of disciplines, from education to sociolinguistics and language acquisition, seem to agree on the fact that HSs are extremely heterogeneous as a group when it comes to their level of proficiency in the heritage language. This study contributes to this question by examining some potential correlations between heritage language learning and the speakers' attitudes and cultural practices. It focuses on an understudied heritage population in the US: Brazilian Portuguese HS. Language proficiency is measured in two ways: through a self-assessment questionnaire, and

independently assessed by two graders using an oral interview. Language attitudes are elicited using a questionnaire and follow-up questions during an interview. The attitudes measured are divided into positive and negative attitudes, and the statements focus on issues related to three topics: (i) the heritage language itself, (ii) immigration, and (iii) bilingualism and biculturalism. Cultural practices are defined as activities in which heritage speakers participate that allow them to engage with their heritage culture, and are elicited by another specific questionnaire. The results of the study are presented in two distinct chapters, one dealing with the quantitative analysis based on the hypotheses about possible correlations between language proficiency, language attitudes and cultural practices, and another one dealing with qualitative findings based on the participants' answers. Overall, the data show a statistically observable correlation between negative attitudes and language proficiency, while positive attitudes and cultural practices do not seem to correlate to the participants' knowledge of the heritage languages. Moreover, the qualitative data indicate a more nuanced picture, where specific characteristics from participants' lives and experiences intertwine with their language development and achievement.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

During the last few decades, as mobility has grown around the world and the number of speakers of minority languages has also expanded in several countries, the interest in studying heritage languages and heritage speakers has been growing steadily not just in the US, Canada, and Europe, but also in several other parts of the world. Despite this growing interest, there is still no consensus in the field about the definition of a heritage speaker. One widely accepted definition in the US comes from Valdés (2000): A heritage speaker is “someone who is raised in a home where a non-English language is spoken and who speaks or at least understands the language and is to some degree bilingual in the home language and in English.” VanDeusen-Scholl (2003) states that heritage speakers are “a heterogeneous group ranging from fluent native speakers to non-speakers who may be generations removed, but who may feel culturally connected to a language.” Referring specifically to heritage language learners in the US, that is to say, heritage speakers who are in the process of (re)learning their heritage language in a formal education context, Draper and Hicks (2000) define them as “...someone who has had exposure to a non-English language outside the formal education system. It most often refers to someone with a home background in the language, but may refer to anyone who has had in-depth exposure to another language. Other terms used to describe this population include ‘native speaker’, ‘bilingual’, and ‘home background’. While these terms are often used interchangeably, they can have very different interpretations.” As we will see below,

in this dissertation I adopt a definition similar to Valdés's, which assumes heritage speakers have some level of communicative ability in their heritage language.

While the field is still working to arrive at a consensus definition of heritage speaker, or even debating the possibility of ever reaching this consensus, several studies targeting heritage speakers have been conducted, dealing with different languages. In the context of the US, these studies have focused particularly on Spanish, Chinese, Korean, and Russian. They deal with different topics, varying from heritage language acquisition (e.g., Montrul, 2002, 2004, 2007, 2008; Polinsky, 1997, 2000, 2006, 2008; Montrul and Polinsky, 2011; Potowski et.al, 2009, Rothman 2007, 2009; Silva-Corvalan, 1994, 2003) to pedagogical implications and specificities of teaching heritage speakers (e.g., Beaudrie and Ducar, 2005; Beaudrie and Fairclough, 2012; Beaudrie et al., 2014; Colombi, 2015; Gutiérrez et al., 1997; Harklau, 2009; Kagan and Dillon, 2001; Kondo-Brown, 2009; Potowski, 2002), heritage speakers' cultural identity (e.g., Duff, 2011; Lee, 2002; Leeman and Martínez, 2007; Showstack, 2012), language attitudes (e.g., Mejías and Anderson, 1988; Cho, 2000; Tse, 2000; Lee, 2002; Mejías et. al, 2003; Lee and Oxelson, 2006; Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009; Guibitosi and de Oliveira, 2020), and language policies (e.g., Cummins, 2005; Lobianco, 2018; Riciento, 2005; Valdés et. al., 2006).

One of the significant immigrant groups, and consequently also relevant group of heritage speakers in the US, is constituted by Brazilians. According to the most recent data available, from the 2017 ACS (American Community Survey)¹, in 2017 450,000 Brazilian immigrants lived in the United States, representing 1% of the 44.5 million immigrants in the country. Half of the immigrants from Brazil live in just three states: Florida (80,000), Massachusetts (65,000), and California (39,000). New Jersey (29,000) and New York (29,000) are the next two top states in terms of con-

¹The data cited in this chapter can be found at the Migration Policy Institute website, at <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/>

centration of Brazilian immigrants, and these five states comprise 64% of the total population of Brazilians in the US. Within those states, this population is concentrated in Broward County in Florida, Middlesex County in Massachusetts, Los Angeles county in California, Essex county in New Jersey, and Queens and Westchester county in New York. The greater Boston area is the American city with the largest number of Brazilian immigrants (51,000), followed by the New York (48,000) and Miami (47,000) metropolitan areas.

Still according to the 2017 ACS, the Brazilian immigrant population has a higher level of income and education, and speaks English better than the general immigrant population in the US. In 2017, the median household income among Brazilian immigrants was \$61,700, compared to \$56,700 for all immigrant households and \$60,800 for U.S.-born households. Brazilian immigrants were also slightly less likely to be in poverty than the overall immigrant population. In 2017, 14% of Brazilian immigrants lived in poverty, compared to 15% of foreign-born and 13% of native-born individuals. 42% of Brazilian immigrants (ages 25 and over) had a bachelor's degree or higher, compared to 31% of the total foreign-born population and 32% of the U.S.-born population. 42% of Brazilian immigrants in the US have limited English proficiency, compared to 48% of the overall foreign-born population in the US.

Despite the significance of the Brazilian immigration to the US, relatively few studies have been conducted specifically about Brazilian Portuguese (BP) heritage speakers. Most studies published about this population investigate language acquisition, but there has also been research developed on discourse analysis, identity, pedagogy, and language policies (e.g., Carvalho, 2010; Jouet-Pastré, 2011; de Lemos, 2013; Milleret, 2012; Pires and Rothman, 2009; Rothman, 2007, 2009; Santos and Silva, 2008).

This study provides further data to deepen our understanding of BP as a heritage language and of heritage speakers of BP in the US. More specifically, it examines the

attitudes towards BP, bilingualism, biculturalism, and immigration of college students in Massachusetts who are heritage speakers of BP, investigating potential correlations between these heritage speakers' level of oral proficiency in BP and their attitudes.

As we will see in chapter 2, previous studies, such as Tse (2000), Lee (2002), Mejías et al. (2003), Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe (2009), MacGregor-Mendoza (2015) and Gubitosi and de Oliveira (2020) have found correlations between attitudes and language maintenance and use in heritage speakers populations. It is reasonable to hypothesize, then, that if attitudes have an impact on language use and maintenance in heritage speakers, they might also have an impact on their levels of proficiency in their heritage language. However, there has not been a lot of research conducted about possible correlations between attitudes and proficiency in heritage speakers, and especially not with BP as the investigated language. In this work I aim to investigate this relationship, examining potential correlations between my informants' oral proficiency level in BP and their attitudes towards BP, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US.

I also investigate a secondary topic, which has to do with heritage speakers' practices in relation to their heritage culture. The concept of cultural practices can be described in different ways. Frese (2015) defines cultural practices as “shared perceptions of how people routinely behave in a culture.”, while Kashima et al. (2015) observe that “...cultural practices include all forms of behaviours that are culturally meaningful; examples include conventionalized nonverbal behaviours (e.g., greetings such as handshaking, bowing, nose touching) through to typical styles of language use (e.g., use of adjectives vs. verbs; Kashima, Kashima, Kim, and Gelfand, 2006) and more complex sequences of coordinated actions supported by social institutions (e.g., buying and selling, going to a restaurant, visiting a dentist, and other types of actions typically called scripts”). In this study, cultural practices are defined as activities in which heritage speakers participate that allow them to engage with their

heritage culture. Examples include listening to music from the heritage country and in the heritage language, participating in holiday celebrations, eating typical food from the heritage country, etc. It seems reasonable to believe that the most contact heritage speakers have with their minority culture, the more chances they will have to receive input in the minority language, which could in turn result in higher levels of proficiency in this language. The hypothesis this study aims to test is that higher degrees of participation in cultural practices such as the ones described above will correlate with higher oral proficiency levels in the informants, while lower cultural participation degrees will correlate with lower oral proficiency levels. As we will see in chapter 2, some studies, such as Lee (2002) and Oh and Au (2005), find a correlation between cultural practices and proficiency in heritage speakers. However, as we will see in chapter 3, these two papers operationalize both oral proficiency and cultural participation differently from this study.

In order to answer these research questions, we first need to establish what a heritage speaker is for the purpose of this study. As mentioned above, there is no general consensus in the field of heritage language research regarding this definition. Some specifically emphasize at least the understanding of the language (Valdés, 2000), while others focus more on cultural connection (VanDeusen-Scholl, 2003). For the purposes of this study, since the oral proficiency is an important variable, heritage speakers need to have some degree of fluency in BP. For this reason, I adopt a definition closer to Valdés', and will consider a heritage speaker '*a person who was born in the US or who immigrated to the US before the age of 6, who is or was raised in a home where BP is spoken, and who is to some degree bilingual in BP and in English.*' The cut-off age of 6 was established because children usually start formal schooling at this age, and by establishing the requirement that the informants have arrived in the US by age 6 it is possible to avoid having a group in which some of the informants went through formal schooling in Portuguese in Brazil while others did not.

Another key variable in this study is language proficiency. This concept can be defined as a person's ability to use a language for a variety of purposes, and it is usually measured separately for the four main linguistic skills: speaking, listening, reading, and writing. Because we are dealing with heritage speakers, the focus will be on the oral comprehension and production abilities. As VanDeusen-Scholl (2003) points out in her above mentioned definition, heritage speakers are usually a very heterogeneous group in terms of their level of proficiency in the heritage language, but as a general rule they tend to have higher levels of proficiency in oral comprehension and expression, and lower levels of proficiency in reading and writing, since many of them have little or no formal education in the heritage language. Carreira and Kagan (2011) is an extensive report about the ACTFL-UCLA National Heritage Languages Research Center (NHLRC) Heritage Language Project, which is a broad study of 1,732 college students who are heritage speakers of 22 different languages. Analyzing the data provided in this report, Swender et al. (2014) observe that when informants were asked to self-assess their proficiency levels in their heritage languages, "almost 68% felt that they were advanced or close to native speakers in listening comprehension and 44% felt they were advanced or native-like in speaking; in comparison, a much smaller number (27 and 19%, respectively) answered that their reading and writing proficiencies were advanced or native-like" (Swender et al., 2014, p.424).

The last key variable in this study is attitudes. Language attitudes specifically can be defined as "a construct underlying the feelings people have about their own language and the language of others" (Crystal, 1992, p.215). Although this definition seems simple, the concept of attitudes can be highly complex. Garrett (2010) states that the concept of attitude "...is not easily defined" when analyzing several different definitions that give more or less weight "to the different features of attitudes" (Garrett, 2010, p.19). If the concept of attitude is hard to define for any social group, it is even more complex in the case of heritage speakers. They are, by def-

inition, bicultural (or even multicultural), although this degree of biculturalism can vary enormously from heritage speaker to heritage speaker. As children of immigrant parents, they will have exposure to the culture of the country to which their parents immigrated and to their parents' minority culture. Some of these heritage speakers will have constant exposure to their parents' culture(s) through trips to their parents' home countries, visits from family members, celebration of cultural traditions, etc., while others may have very limited exposure to the minority culture(s). As the child grows up, their own decisions in terms of how much exposure and participation in the minority culture they want to have will necessarily impact their cultural identity and their attitudes towards their heritage language and towards their culture.

Another factor that plays a role in the construction of this identity and attitudes is how the dominant culture evaluates the minority culture and language. Heritage speakers of languages with high prestige in the majority society might have more positive attitudes towards their heritage language, while speakers of languages with lower societal prestige may have less positive attitudes towards their heritage language, unless family and personal efforts contribute to elevate the status of the heritage language for the heritage speaker, or the speaker happens to live in a community that has strong cultural values that could potentially counter the more negative ideas coming from the broader society.

In the specific case of BP heritage speakers in the US, Americans in general have very little information about the Portuguese language and about Brazil. Writing about Brazilians in Massachusetts, Rubinstein-Avila (2005), claims that Brazilians are an 'invisible minority', and that more studies are needed about this particular group, especially in states with higher concentration of this population, such as Massachusetts. However, despite this general lack of awareness about Brazil and Brazilians, many people in the US will know that Brazil is a Latin American country, and this particular group of countries does not normally carry a lot of cultural prestige

in the American society. Many heritage speakers of BP will then be in a situation similar to heritage speakers of Latin American Spanish; in other words, they do not come from a country or speak a language (or at least not a variety of a language) that commands high prestige in the US (McEvoy, 2017), despite the fact that, as stated above, Brazilian immigrants in the US tend to be more educated and have higher incomes than the general immigrant population.

Different heritage speakers will process this ‘cultural evaluation input’ coming from the majority society in different ways, and all these experiences will result in different attitudes towards the Portuguese language and the Brazilian culture, and towards bilingualism, biculturalism and immigration. I want to investigate whether these attitudes correlate with oral proficiency levels in heritage speakers of BP. The hypothesis I want to explore in this study is that heritage speakers who have mostly positive attitudes towards BP, about being bilingual and bicultural, and about immigration in the US will have higher levels of oral proficiency in BP when compared to the ones who have more negative attitudes towards these same topic areas. I also hypothesize that heritage speakers who interact more frequently with their minority culture will have a higher level of oral proficiency in BP, while the ones who have infrequent interactions with their heritage culture will have lower levels of oral proficiency in BP.

After this first chapter, which introduces and contextualizes the general topic of this dissertation and its main research questions and hypotheses, there are five others. The second chapter analyzes previous work about heritage speakers of different languages that is particularly relevant to this study. Specifically, a few studies investigating correlations between attitudes and oral proficiency, others that examine correlations between attitudes and language use and maintenance, and some articles studying correlations between heritage speakers’ cultural practices and their proficiency levels. The third chapter provides specific information about the goals, proce-

dures and methodology for the study. Section 3.1 presents the context of the study and provides information about the group of participants. In section 3.2, we see the research questions and hypotheses. Sections 3.3, 3.4, and 3.5 describe how each one of the main variables has been operationalized and coded, starting with the evaluation of the participants' oral proficiency, and ending with how cultural practices and attitudes were measured. Finally, in section 3.6 I look into the information collected using the questionnaire and the interview. Chapter 4 presents the study's results and a detailed analysis of the data. In section 4.1, I describe the results per variable and look into the performance of the participants in each one of the tasks. In section 4.2, I answer the research questions by analyzing the correlations between the main variables presented before. Section 4.3 presents further analysis of the data and investigates the potential role that other variables collected in the questionnaire could play in the participants' oral proficiency. Chapter 5 presents qualitative analyses of the data obtained through the questionnaires and the oral interview, which are the data collection instruments employed in this study. There we can find a more nuanced view of the data with the testimonies of several participants about the topics elicited in the questionnaire. After analyzing individual opinions on their positive and negative attitudes in sections 5.1 and 5.2, I present a detailed picture of eight participants, four with the highest oral performance in their heritage language and four with the lowest one, in section 5.3. Finally, in chapter 6, I present some final remarks about the achieved goals, together with the limitations of the study and some suggestions for future work.

CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF PREVIOUS WORK

Since at least the late 1980s and early 1990s, several studies have been conducted in North America with the aim of investigating possible correlations between language maintenance and proficiency levels in heritage speakers and variables such as cultural identity and language attitudes. Some of these studies use qualitative methods, while others use quantitative methods, and a few use a mix of both. This chapter presents and discusses some of these studies, which were particularly selected because they provide valuable information and insight in relation to the topics investigated in this study, while at the same time pointing to areas of research that are still open and deserve to be further investigated.

Hakuta and D'andrea (1992) investigate potential relationships between language proficiency, language choice, and language attitudes in Mexican-American, Spanish-English bilingual high school students. Their 308 informants come from a high school in central California, located in a community where 51% of the population was of Mexican descent at the time of data collection, and had settled in the area in the 20 years prior to the study being conducted. The students were enrolled into either a Spanish as a Foreign language or a Spanish for Spanish-speakers course in their high school, where both classes are electives and the students themselves choose in which class to enroll. 100 students were enrolled in Spanish as a foreign language, while 208 were enrolled in Spanish for Spanish speakers.

The first task informants were asked to carry out was to complete a background questionnaire, which included questions about students' birthplace, date of immigra-

tion if they were not born in the US, the birthplace of their parents and grandparents, their sibling structure, the age when they first started to speak English, and the extent of their contact with Mexico. Based on the data gathered, the researchers divided the informants into six groups, according to what they call the depth of their familial establishment in the United States. In depth 1, the students were born in Mexico, and arrived in the US after 10 years of age (N=20); in depth 2, the students were born in Mexico, and arrived in the US between the ages of 6 and 10 (N=31); in depth 3, they were born in Mexico and arrived in the US at 5 years-old or younger (N=60); in depth 4, students were born in the US of parents born in Mexico (N=123), in depth 5, students were born in the US with at least one parent also born in the US (N=55); and in depth 6, the students were born in the US, with at least one parent and associated grandparents born in the US (N=19). (Hakuta and D'andrea, 1992, p.10).

The students in each group were assessed for language proficiency in Spanish and in English in two different ways. The first, by answering the question “How well do you speak and understand Spanish/English?” according to a 7-point likert-scale that ranged from “not at all” to “perfect”. The second by means of a productive vocabulary test, a test of the ability to detect grammatical errors, and a cloze test. 102 students took the vocabulary test, 123 students took the grammar mistakes test, and 126 students took the cloze test. The authors do not elaborate on why different groups of informants were assessed with different instruments, which could arguably be problematic in terms of reliability. They explain only that in order to create a single measure of language proficiency, they standardized each student's score within their group.

Students were also asked about their language choice in various domains, such as with adults in their households, with siblings, with friends, etc. Six responses were available to them: “only Spanish”, “mostly Spanish”, “both languages equally”,

“mostly English”, “only English”, and “not applicable”. To test students’ attitudes towards bilingualism, the authors used 21 statements that should be judged using a 7-point likert-scale, ranging from “strongly disagree” to “strongly agree”.

The study’s data show that loss of proficiency occurs most pronouncedly between informants in depth 5 in relation to depth 4, but that the shift in language choice occurs across all depths. The results also show that Spanish proficiency is primarily determined by adult language practices at home, and is not affected by the informants’ language choice in other situations or by their attitudes in relation to bilingualism. However, the subjects’ attitudes were correlated to their language choice in contexts other than in the home. Since the study findings show that adult language practices at home is the main factor determining participants’ Spanish proficiency, the authors state that when their informants move out of their parents’ home and become adults themselves, their own children’s language choice will probably be affected by their parents’ attitudes and language choice as teenagers. The authors conclude then that intergenerational transmission can be affected by teenagers attitudes and language choice.

Another very important point the authors make is that they find a discrepancy between the subjects’ self-reported proficiency and their actual proficiency, both in English and Spanish, as measured by the vocabulary and grammar tests. According to their findings, this discrepancy appears to be related to attitudes, especially in the case of Spanish. More positive attitudes correlate to higher proficiency self-assessment scores, while more negative attitudes correlate to lower proficiency self-assessment scores. Based on these results the authors call attention to the potential inadequacies of using self-reporting as an assessment measure both in the case of language choice and language proficiency (Hakuta and D’andrea, 1992, p.34).

Building on the findings by Hakuta and D’andrea (1992) that show Spanish maintenance among heritage speakers of Spanish primarily tied to the adult use of Span-

ish in the household, Lambert and Taylor (1996) investigate the role the mothers of Cuban-American heritage speakers of Spanish in the Miami area have on these speakers' language choice and language proficiency in Spanish. Their sample comprised 108 Cuban American mothers from Miami, Florida, with an average age of 37 years old and approximately 17 years of US residency (Lambert and Taylor, 1996, p.481). The informants were selected randomly from lists of middle school students enrolled in the Dade County public school system. The ethnicity of the informants was established through school records, as well as the family's socioeconomic status, based on eligibility for free school lunches. Based on this socioeconomic information, the authors formed two groups, a "working-class" and a "middle-class" one, determined by free lunch eligibility and place of residency. The authors observe that the educational attainment of the mothers in the two samples is essentially identical. On average, they graduated from junior or senior high school. In terms of length of stay in the US, in both groups most informants came to the US before the Mariel exodus of 1980, but the working-class sample has on average 3 years less of US residency than the middle class sample.

The central research questions for the study are related to the possible correlations among the respondents' ratings of their own fluency in English and Spanish, the fluency of each of their children (most mothers had two or more children), and particular attitudes, values and feelings they hold about bilingualism and biculturalism (Lambert and Taylor, 1996, p.483). The methodology used in the study includes a values and attitudes questionnaire, with statements in Spanish and presented orally, since some of the informants are not literate. The informants had to react to the statements according to a 11-point likert-scale, ranging from "not at all" to "definitely agree." As they listened to the statements, respondents used cards to give their answers. When rating their children's competence in English, the mothers were instructed to consider teachers' comments and school report cards, as well as their

own impression. The ratings ranged from “not fluent at all” to “native-like command of the language.” When assessing their children’s competence in school, the mothers were also instructed to consider teachers’ comments and school report cards, as well as their own impressions, and the ratings ranged from “very poor student” to “very good student”. The mothers were also asked to evaluate their own fluency both in Spanish and English. When analyzing the data, the authors looked for correlations between (i) the Spanish and English fluency of each mother and that of her offspring; (ii) the mothers’ and the children’s fluency in Spanish and English and the children’s school performance, (iii) mothers’ attitudes and values and their children’s language fluency and school performance (Lambert and Taylor, 1996, p.484).

The study results show that in both socioeconomic groups mothers rate their offspring English ability (9-10, where 10 is the highest possible score) higher than their ability in Spanish (8-9 on the same scale), although both these ratings indicate a high degree of bilingualism. As to their own ability in English, the mothers’ average rate is a 5, which lead the authors to conclude that parents may be more successful in transmitting the minority language to their offspring when they themselves are not very fluent in English. In terms of the correlations between fluency in English and Spanish and school performance, the authors find that for the working-class group, fluency in English is clearly correlated to good school performance, while fluency in Spanish is not correlated to school performance. The opposite is true for the middle class group, where no significant correlation between English fluency and school performance was found, but a significant correlation between fluency in Spanish and school performance could be detected. The authors speculate that “...the values and expectations of working-class families may encourage them to emphasize English competency over Spanish for their children whereas another set of values and expectations, based more on heritage culture and language pride, may encourage middle-class families to emphasize Spanish.” (Lambert and Taylor, 1996, p.497). The

authors conclude that working-class mothers appear to encourage a “subtractive” form of bilingualism and biculturalism for their children, where greater emphasis is put on developing skills in English than in Spanish, and the adoption of an American way of life is encouraged at the expense of the heritage culture. The caveat here is that the Hispanic community in Miami is a very vibrant one, and the authors comment that it can be strong enough to attenuate this assimilation process. The middle-class mothers, on the other hand, are oriented towards an “additive” form of bilingualism and biculturalism for their children, one that protects the heritage language and culture while the Americanization takes place (Lambert and Taylor, 1996, p.496). In trying to explain these differences, the authors say: “We are inclined to interpret the contrasts emerging in this pilot study in terms of the privileges associated with social class status in the American scene. Our sample of middle-class mothers realize that their families can function and flourish in America by developing a bicultural identity, i. e. being themselves linguistically and culturally, while becoming as Americanized as is manageable. (...) The working-class families, by contrast, have apparently developed a quite different perspective on how to survive and become economically competitive in the USA. They have not made it as well, and they realize that their children will more likely have to compete with other working-class Americans, which gives them the impetus to become American as rapidly as possible. In addition, they may feel a push away from an Hispanic identity by the attitudes of the better-off Cuban Americans in the community. Regardless of parental desires for biculturalism and bilingualism, the success of these families depends more on developing competence in English and learning the American style of life.” (Lambert and Taylor, 1996, p.497-498). This study points strongly to the possible influence of socioeconomic class and status on the level of bilingualism of heritage speakers, a topic that will be explored in many other studies.

Tse (2000) studies the ethnic identity of a group of Americans and Canadians of Asian descent and the influence of this ethnic identity on their attitudes towards their heritage languages, and ultimately on their interest in maintaining and/or developing their abilities in these languages. Using qualitative methods, Tse analyzes personal narratives of 39 Americans and Canadians of Asian descent. The data comes from corpora of published narratives, and almost all of them contain examples of conflicting identities and the desire, among the informants, to be accepted by their white peers and to belong to the majority culture (Tse, 2000, p.194). According to the study, language is an important element in this acceptance, and speaking English well is vital to these informants. At the same time, speaking the heritage language works against being accepted as a member of the majority group. According to Tse, “The desire to be part of the dominant culture translated into negative feelings toward the HL but positive attitudes toward the dominant language.” (Tse, 2000, p.195). Tse’s conclusion is that only when bilingualism and knowledge of other languages are valued by members of the majority group will heritage speakers have positive attitudes towards their heritage language. According to her, it is especially important that official institutions, such as schools, value and promote the teaching of heritage languages: “It is likely that official sanction of HL teaching and the elevation of the subject to regular school subject status brings to it prestige and value that helps promote student interest in the language. It may also be the case that the inclusion of the HL in the mainstream curriculum significantly increases student attitudes toward the language and may, because of its close association to the ethnic group (Tse 1998a), have a favorable effect on EM students’ attitudes toward the ethnic minority culture in general.” (Tse, 2000, p.198). Tse points to a very important aspect to consider when studying heritage speakers, which is the perceptions heritage speakers have about the majority culture’s attitudes toward their specific heritage language and culture, and towards minority languages and cultures inside the majority culture in

general. This perception can influence heritage speakers' desire and motivation to maintain their ties to their culture and to invest in maintaining and/or improving their level of proficiency in their heritage language.

Lee (2002) investigates a potential correlation between young Korean-Americans' degree of biculturalism and their language choice between English and Korean. The informants' degree of biculturalism is assessed through a likert-scale questionnaire that mixes language attitudes statements and cultural and linguistic practices statements. The study also investigates a potential correlation between the informants' degree of biculturalism and their self-assessed level of oral proficiency in Korean. The participants are 40 second-generation Korean-American undergraduate and graduate college students. Half of them were recruited from a university on the east coast and the other half from a university on the west coast. There were 25 (62.5%) males and 15 (37.5%) females among the informants. The age of the informants ranged from 17 to 26 years, with an average age of 21.4 years. The majority of the informants were born in the US ($n = 23$, 57.5%), but some were born in Korea. 11 came to the US between the ages of one and five (27.5%), and six immigrated to the US between the ages of six and 10 (15%). The informants were all native-like speakers of English (Lee, 2002, p.120).

The study uses a questionnaire as its method of data collection. Part A of the questionnaire contains 20 questions about the personal history of the informant; part B contains 17 questions about the participants' proficiency in Korean, and also about the frequency and domains of Korean use; part C contains statements about cultural identity. The participants are supposed to rate each statement according to their degree of agreement with each one of them, using a 5-point likert-scale. Half of the questions relate to American culture items, and the other half to Korean culture items. The last part of the questionnaire consists of 10 open-ended questions about the participants' attitudes towards cultural identity and heritage language maintenance.

Unsurprisingly, in relation to the language proficiency and language use portion of the data, Lee's findings show that informants who came to the US later tend to self-rate their proficiency in Korean as higher than the ones born in the US and the ones who immigrated earlier, between 1 and 5 years-old. The study also finds that the non-US-born group uses significantly more Korean than the US-born group when speaking to their parents, showing a greater attachment to the language of their country of birth (Lee, 2002, p.124). Still in terms of heritage language use, female informants report using more English than males regardless of interlocutors and location of speech, which leads Lee to conclude that males "seem to display a stronger ethnic attachment through the use of language markers" (Lee, 2002, p.124). Although all informants classify themselves as English-dominant and say that they rarely use Korean only, the study finds that the ones who associate more with Koreans or Korean-Americans report using more Korean, and they also report having higher levels of proficiency in their heritage language. We have to remember, though, that proficiency levels in this study are self-reported and, as Hakuta and D'andrea (1992) point out, there might be significant discrepancy between self-reported levels of proficiency and independently assessed levels of proficiency.

Lee (2002) reports other interesting findings in terms of heritage language proficiency. For instance, male informants tend to rate themselves higher in their ability to read, write, and speak Korean, while females tend to rate themselves higher in pronunciation and in their ability to use Korean in a socially appropriate manner (e.g. honorifics) (Lee, 2002, p.122). When asked if they had any intention to return to Korea or had family members who did, those informants who reply "yes" also tend to rate themselves as having higher proficiency in Korean, while the ones who answer "no" tend to rate themselves as having lower proficiency in Korean. Lee interprets these results as an indication that "having a purpose for the use of language seems to be a major factor that can motivate individuals to maintain Korean." (Lee, 2002,

p.122). The study also finds that informants who had visited Korea more than four times by the time of data collection rate themselves as more proficient than the ones who visited less, which leads the author to conclude that having more opportunities to visit Korea is also beneficial for these heritage speakers' proficiency levels, at least when they self-assess it (Lee, 2002, p.122). Interestingly, she finds that, among the informants who attended weekend supplementary Korean language school as kids and teenagers, 26.65% rate themselves as having low proficiency in Korean, while among the ones who did not attend such schools 14.35% rate themselves as having higher proficiency in Korean, which shows that these schools do not have a very significant influence on the informants' self-assessed levels of proficiency in their heritage language. Lee speculates that problems with the design of such supplementary language programs and the fact that these learning environments are labelled as "supplementary" might be the reason why the informants did not feel motivated to attend them and did not find them very helpful (Lee, 2002, p.123). In consonance with Tse (2000), Lee states: "it is evident that these second-generation Korean-Americans want an opportunity to learn their heritage language, but want to do so in a socially accepted and supported way, instead of having to learn it as an extracurricular subject. Moreover, having to learn Korean in a supplementary environment usually entails attending Saturday heritage language schools where instruction is mostly limited to students of Korean ethnic background. This may be problematic for children in the adolescent stage who want to participate in activities with their 'American' friends. Activities that are foreign to their American friends set them off as being different, which is psychologically very stressful for children at this age. If the study of heritage languages and cultures were to be included in the school curriculum, it would give children the opportunity to maintain their heritage language and also provide non-heritage learners opportunities to learn about other cultures and languages. In light of multicultural education, this will provide the spirit of acceptance that our society is

seeking and also reinforce the value of diversity.” (Lee, 2002, p.123-124). Supporting this conclusion, 85% of Lee’s informants mention that if Korean courses had been offered in their elementary and/or secondary school they would have enrolled. The informants also mention that these classes would have made “a tremendous difference in their attitude towards Korean study and their proficiency (Lee, 2002, p.123)”.

To assess informants’ cultural identity, the study uses cultural identity statements aimed to find out if they were Korean-oriented, American-oriented, of biculturally-oriented. The questionnaire consists of 12 Korean orientation items and 12 American orientation items, and informants use a 5-point likert-scale to express their degree of agreement with each one of them. Examples of the statements are, for instance, “I enjoy Korean music” / “I enjoy American music” or “Knowing Korean will help me become successful” / “English will help me become successful” (Lee, 2002, p.126). The results show that a majority of respondents view themselves as both Korean and American, and they also want other people to recognize these two identities in them (Lee, 2002, p.127-128). In terms of the effect of this cultural identity on their self-assessed language proficiency level in Korean, the author states that “The stronger the identification with the Korean items, the higher the Korean language proficiency” (Lee, 2002, p.129). However, the study also finds that those who rate themselves higher in terms of proficiency also identify themselves to be more bicultural, which leads the author to conclude that “in order to promote biculturalism, maintenance of the heritage language must also be supported, which in turn fosters bilingualism” (Lee, 2002, p.129). The study’s final conclusion is that positive attitudes towards being bilingual and bicultural may lead to higher proficiency levels in the heritage language, at least as self-reported by the informants.

Lee (2002) confirms what Tse (2000) had already established: It is not just heritage speakers’ own attitudes that influence language maintenance and choice, and possibly language proficiency. Societal attitudes towards specific heritage languages

and towards bilingualism and biculturalism also affect heritage speakers' motivation to maintain their heritage languages. The fact that some heritage languages are seldom offered in schools in North America is interpreted by Lee's and Tse's informants as a sign that their language is not important or significant enough to merit the recognition of society in general, which reduces their motivation and desire to speak that language and to invest their time in maintaining it. For the purposes of this study, though, the most significant finding from Lee (2002) is that both cultural practices and attitudes, which the author combines into a single variable, can correlate to oral proficiency in heritage speakers. To be more specific, they can correlate to how heritage speakers perceive their own proficiency level, since oral proficiency in Lee (2002) is self-assessed.

Mejías et al. (2003) investigate the relationship between language maintenance and attitudes towards Spanish among Mexican-American students attending the University of Texas-Pan American, located in the Lower Rio Grande Valley of Texas, in the southern part of the state, near the border with Mexico. In this university, at the time of data collection, 85% of students identified as Hispanic, and what makes the area so unique for linguistic investigations is that, according to the authors, "most of its permanent residents routinely use both Spanish and English in all domains for daily communication." (Mejías et al., 2003, p.138). This study replicates a previous one published by Mejías and Anderson in 1988, and it compares the two sets of data to investigate possible changes in attitudes during the approximately 20-year gap between the collection of the two. There was an impressive growth in population in the area between the two data collections (82% from 1980 to 2000), as well as several significant sociodemographic changes. For instance, in 1982 (the year the data was collected for the study published in 1988) 95% of the population was Mexican-American, while in 2000 (the year the data was collected for the study published in 2003) 89% were Hispanic, which includes locally-born Mexican-Americans, as well

as immigrants from Mexico, Central and South America, the Caribbean and Spain (Mejías et al., 2003, p. 138). Besides that, many other immigrant groups from countries such as Korea, the Philippines, India, and several Arab countries established a significant presence in the area (Mejías et al., 2003, p.140). Another important change was that education opportunities multiplied in the region. While the 1982 generation had fewer options in terms of post-secondary education, and mostly aspired to become teachers, social workers, and accountants, the 2000 generation had many more opportunities to get professional degrees and become doctors, engineers, professors, dentists, etc. All these changes led the authors to postulate the need for a long-term study investigating potential changes in the attitudes of bilinguals towards Spanish and the reasons why they choose to use Spanish in their daily lives.

For the 2003 study, the same personal background and attitudes questionnaires used in the 1988 paper were sent by mail to a random sample of undergraduate students at UTPA who had self-identified as Mexican-American on their college application forms. 279 students returned the completed questionnaires, but four had to be excluded because they did not identify as bilinguals in their personal background questionnaires. On the attitudes questionnaire, the informants are asked to select three statements among a total of twelve that better explain their reasons to use Spanish rather than English in different domains of their lives. The researchers then establish a ranking of reasons why a bilingual chooses Spanish over English. Those statements are finally classified according to four dimensions, as established by Hofman (1977): instrumental, sentimental, value, and communication (Mejías et al., 2003, p.142). Examples of the statements used are: “I use Spanish to feel good about myself (sentimental); I use Spanish because it helps me make money at my job (instrumental); I use Spanish because I do not want to lose my language (value); I use Spanish because I like to listen to Spanish programs on radio and television (communication).” (Mejías et al., 2003, p.142-143).

The 1988 study found that communication reasons were the ones selected more frequently, followed by value, instrumental, and sentimental. On the 2003 paper there were changes in the percentages of students choosing reasons within each dimension, but this order remained. The percentages for 1988 were: Communication (45.8), Value (23.5), Instrumental (14), Sentimental (12.6). For 2003, the percentages were: Communication (39.8), Value (26.3), Instrumental (12.2), Sentimental (10.1). The authors comment that not only the attitudes appear in the same rank order, but that the observable shifts in percentages are not sufficient to show a statistically significant difference after the statistical analyses (Mejías et al., 2003, p.146). In 1988, the authors suggested that the fact that most students selected communication items would indicate that Spanish was going to be maintained in the Lower Rio Grande Valley of Texas, since the language was used mainly for communication. In 2003 the students' motivations are still primarily communicative, even if the percentage of informants selecting communication items decreased. There was also a slight increase in the value dimension. Since both are "public domain" dimensions (Mejías et al., 2003, p.147), and even fewer students selected sentimental items, a "private domain" dimension, in 2003 than in 1988, the authors conclude that Spanish will likely be maintained in the Lower Rio Grande Valley of Texas, as it was during the almost 20 years that separate both sets of data. According to them, sentimentality towards a language as the sole factor motivating its use is seldom a strong enough factor to ensure its maintenance. However, attitudes classified as communication or value/language loyalty are better predictors of language maintenance (Mejías et al., 2003, p.148). Both the 1988 and the 2003 studies show the importance of not treating attitudes as a uniform concept when investigating their influence on language maintenance, since some types of attitudes, in this case, the ones pertaining the public domain, can be better predictors of language maintenance than others.

Beckstead and Toribio (2003) is a mostly qualitative study of Latino junior high school students' attitudes in relation to Spanish (their heritage language) and English (their environment language). The study was carried out with 13 and 14 year-old students enrolled in the ESL (English as a second language) program at Goleta Valley Junior High School, in Goleta, a suburb of Santa Barbara, CA, in 1998. The study is important in the sense that it seeks to find out about the students' attitudes about their languages, not their parents' or school educators', which the authors believe is an important step for the goal of promoting bilingualism (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.155). The area has a high percentage of Hispanic population, and in the academic year 1998-99, out of 900 students enrolled in the school, approximately one-third were classified as Hispanic. Many of these students come from families that had resided in the area for generations, and are English native speakers. Others had arrived in the US very young, and had significant English proficiency when they entered junior high school, while others were newcomers who spoke very little or no English (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.156). The Hispanic students in the school represented then a continuum, from English native speakers with very little proficiency in Spanish, to highly functional English-Spanish bilinguals, to a small number classified as non-English speaking (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.156). For placement in the ESL program, students were tested upon entering school and then biannually, and placed in courses according to their language skills, varying from classroom instruction and course materials in Spanish to "sheltered" classes in which the materials were in English.

43 students participated in the study, and they were placed into 2 groups. The first one consists of students who had arrived in the US within 12 months prior to the study. These students received three periods per day of instruction in Spanish with materials in Spanish, and three periods of English instruction with two teachers, one of which was also proficient in Spanish. The second group consists of students

who had arrived as school-age children at varying times and ages, and demonstrated beginning to advanced proficiency in English. Of the initial 43 students, only 28 completed all the study materials. These 28 were divided into three groups, separated by length of residency in the US. The first group consists of students with 0.4 to 2.11 years of US residency, the second group consists of students with 3 to 7 years of US residency, and the third group consists of students with 9-14 years of residency in the US. Each student participated into a four-part test. Part 1 involved filling out a background questionnaire, part 2 consisted of measuring language proficiency and language use, part 3 was a survey about language attitudes, and part 4 was an open-ended questionnaire about the instrumental and integrative value of both Spanish and English.

In terms of language use, the study finds that Spanish is used at home by all participants, and all of them interact exclusively in Spanish with at least one relative. With peers, however, English is usually favored and may completely displace Spanish in some cases (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.158). Not surprisingly, those with 9 to 14 years of residency in the US tend to use English more, especially with siblings, friends, and schoolmates, reserving Spanish for the home. According to the authors, in this group, several informants demonstrate “Spanish-language abilities that are largely receptive or conversational” (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.159), since they received limited formal instruction in Spanish. Unfortunately, the authors do not present any further discussion about the informants’ language proficiency levels in English or in Spanish, and do not draw any correlations between proficiency levels and language use or attitudes.

In terms of language vitality, the vast majority of participants in all groups attach a high value to Spanish, as well as to Latino culture, and the authors comment that a positive school environment in relation to Spanish certainly is a contributing factor in this evaluation. English is also valued, but interestingly it is less valued than Spanish

by the informants. Except for one informant, which the authors say is English-dominant in all speech domains, all the others attribute higher value to Spanish than English, which seems to be in consonance with the extensive use of Spanish in Latino homes and neighborhoods in the area (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.161).

Regarding language attitudes, the authors comment that while the students are anxious to learn English and list knowing English as a necessity to having success in the US, many say they feel more comfortable when learning in Spanish, because they are able to fully understand everything that is said in the classroom. While they understand the need to be placed in the ESL program, they also want to have access to the full school curriculum, available only in English. This dilemma is reflected in the kinds of attitudes students express about both languages. While all the informants endorse English on instrumental grounds, very few of them do this on affective grounds. Most feel English will remain “foreign” to them (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.164).

In their conclusion, the authors, similarly to Cho (2000) and Lee (2002), observe that “the mere act of acknowledging that student’s heritage language is worthy of examination will foment an affective environment that translates into greater engagement on the part of the students (...) The advantages of bilingualism should be emphasized for all - not only for those who may wish to maintain a heritage language, but for those who will acquire a foreign language as well.” (Beckstead and Toribio, 2003, p.167)

Oh and Au (2005) study sociocultural background variables that could potentially predict the successful mastery of a heritage language by adult learners. Their informants are 55 Latino college students enrolled in second-year Spanish classes at a Southern California large university, and the study investigates whether three background variables, which they define as cultural identification, cultural participation, and use of Spanish outside class, have any impact on informants’ mastery of Spanish

accent and grammar. The authors observe that up to the point of their study publication, there have been well-documented sociocultural models for second language learners, but not for heritage learners, and they aimed to start filling this void with their study.

The participants, as mentioned, are all college students, and they were recruited from second-year Spanish classes at their Southern California university. In order to qualify, the participants need to have at least one Latino parent (28 participants have two Latino parents, while 27 have only one Latino parent.) The participants range from having no experience with Spanish before taking a class in high school or college to having spoken Spanish until at least adolescence (Oh and Au, 2005, p.232). The participants had to complete three tasks: Fill out a questionnaire about their language background, identification with Latino culture, participation in Latino cultural activities, and use of Spanish outside the classroom; participate in a language ability assessment that evaluates their mastery of accent and grammar; and participate in a follow-up interview about their language background.

For the analyses, and based on data gathered from the participants' background questionnaire, the authors divide the informants into seven groups, according to their previous experience with Spanish: Novice learner (started learning Spanish in college), novice learner (started learning Spanish in high school), minimal childhood exposure (they heard Spanish occasionally during childhood, but never consistently), childhood overhearer (they regularly overheard other people speaking Spanish during childhood), childhood addressee (they were regularly addressed in Spanish during childhood), childhood speaker (they spoke Spanish regularly until about age 10, but only minimally after that), and regular speaker (they regularly spoke Spanish until at least age 14.) To measure identification with Latino culture, the authors use five items from the affirmation and belonging subscale of the Multigroup Ethnic Identity Measure (MEIM) (Phinney, 1992). In this scale, participants have to express

their degree of agreement with statements using a 4-point likert-scale, varying from “strongly disagree” to “strongly agree”. An example of a statement used is: “I am happy that I am a member of the group I belong to.” (Oh and Au, 2005, p.233). The answers were averaged, giving each participant a cultural identification score. The participation in Latino culture was measured using modified items from the MEIM ethnic behaviors subscale and other group orientation subscale. An example of a statement used is “I like meeting and getting to know people of Latino background.” (Oh and Au, 2005, p.233). The answers were also averaged, giving each participant a cultural participation score. The authors also asked participants to assess their use of Spanish using a questionnaire about the frequency with each they did activities such as reading and writing in Spanish, listening to or watching radio or TV in Spanish, etc. The statements are assessed using a 5-point frequency scale, varying from “not at all” (zero points) to “everyday” (5 points).

The authors assess the participants’ language abilities in terms of accent and grammar mastery. In order to do that, they asked each one of them to tell a story from an abridged version of a wordless picture book. For the accent mastery portion, the recordings were first graded by two native Spanish speakers for narrative accent. They used a five-point scale varying from “very strong foreign accent, definitely non-native” (1 point) to “no foreign accent, definitively native” (5 points). The two raters scores were averaged to give each participant one narrative accent score. The study also evaluates the participants’ production of specific Spanish phonemes (Spanish stop consonants) by asking them to pronounce target words embedded in a sentence frame: “*Diga* (target word), *por favor*.” 48 native speakers of Spanish were asked to rate the pronunciation of the target phonemes using the same scale mentioned above for narrative accent. Their scores were averaged to give each participant a phoneme accent rating. For the grammar mastery assessment, two other Spanish native speakers rated informants’ story narration for grammar using a five-point scale

similar to the one used for accent. Besides that, the authors also include a grammaticality judgment task to assess participants' ability to detect errors. Participants hear native speakers say a sentence, and they have to judge whether it was grammatical or agrammatical. The agrammatical sentences involve issues with number, gender, and person markers in noun phrases, and verb tense and aspect marking.

The study results show that all background variables (cultural identification, cultural participation, and use of Spanish outside class in the present and in high school) are positively correlated to the accent ratings, and that the use of Spanish outside class is positively correlated to the grammar abilities in the narratives. The grammaticality judgments, however, are not correlated to any of the background variables. Besides these correlations, the results also show a strong positive relationship between cultural identification and cultural participation, and also between current use of Spanish outside the classroom and use of Spanish in high school. The authors conclude that "...encouraging HLLs to explore their cultural identification, to participate in cultural activities, and to use the language in a variety of contexts outside of the classroom may help these language learners to successfully master the language." (Oh and Au, 2005, p.239). From the methodological point of view, this study provides important contributions, since it shows innovative ways of measuring language proficiency, such as through an accent mastery test.

Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe (2009) is an ethnographic study with 18 families living in two Chinese immigrant communities in Philadelphia, conducted with the goal of investigating the immigrant parents' attitudes towards their heritage speaker children's maintenance of their heritage language, and the children's attitudes toward their heritage language. It also studies the efforts promoted by the parents to help their children learn and/or maintain their heritage language, and the children's reactions to those efforts. The two communities are very different, according to the authors. The University City community is "composed of mostly well-educated university students,

scholars, or professionals in high-tech companies.” (Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009, p.80). These families are identified as “Mandarin-speaking”, because they largely speak Mandarin, which is the standard Chinese spoken language, as their primary language. The Chinatown community, on the other hand, is comprised mostly of manual laborers who have little formal education and typically work in restaurants or factories. These families are identified as “Fujianese-speakers”, because all of these participants come from the Fujian province in China, and speak a dialect that is significantly different from Mandarin. Despite those differences, the parents in the two different sets of informants have in common the fact of being all first-generation immigrants who entered the US after reaching adulthood. The majority of parents interviewed were mothers (15 out of 20.) The children in the families were either born in the US or arrived in the US young enough to have started their formal education in American schools. There are 18 children in the informant group (4 boys and 14 girls), with ages ranging from six to 14 years-old. Six children come from the Fujianese-speaking families, and 12 from the Mandarin-speaking families (Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009, p.80).

The data collection methods include ethnographic interviews, conducted either in Mandarin or in English, according to the participant’s preference. The authors note that most of the adults’ interviews were conducted in Mandarin, while most of the kids’ interviews were conducted in English. The data collection included also participant observations, conducted by one of the authors, who is an active member of the two communities. She was also a Chinese teacher to second-generation HL learners in a weekend language school in a Philadelphia suburb and volunteered to help in a Sunday school in a Chinese church in Chinatown for almost a year (Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009, p.81-82).

The data shows that in general the parents value a lot their home language. Some see it mostly as a resource that children could use in their academic life and future

career, while others see it more as closely related to their ethnic identity, or others still as a necessary family link contributing to family cohesion. The Fujianese-speaking parents, who speak Fujianese at home, nonetheless see the value of their children's maintaining their abilities in Mandarin, which the authors see as refutation to the idea that immigrant children's language is simply the language spoken at home by the family. This is due in part to the fact that Mandarin is the prestige variety of Chinese, and also the one that has a written form, as opposed to other dialects, like Fujianese, that only exist in the spoken form. As a result, the Fujianese-speaking parents in the study do not wish for their children to maintain Fujianese, but rather Mandarin. The other reason for the parents to wish for the maintenance of their children's heritage language is the perceived connection between the heritage language and ethnic identity. According to the authors, the sense of ethnic identity is very strong among Chinese immigrants, and maintaining the language is part of maintaining this identity. Without the Chinese language, a person is no longer Chinese. The third reason mentioned by the parents for HL maintenance has to do with family cohesion. Several of them worry that without Chinese, they will not be able to be united as a family, since the Chinese is the preferred language of interaction for the parents. Even the well-educated informants report that they are more comfortable speaking Chinese, regardless of their proficiency level in English. (Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009, p.83-84)

As a result of the value placed on heritage language maintenance by these parents, they all make considerable efforts to help their children maintain their heritage language. Most try to use only Chinese as their home language. Several of them also teach Chinese to their children formally, using books, textbooks and other materials brought from China. Most parents also make deliberate efforts to expose their children to Chinese, participating in activities within the Chinese community, sending them to weekend Chinese schools, and taking them to visit China on vacations. De-

spite all this effort and the positive attitudes of Chinese parents, however, the authors report that few of the children interviewed see their heritage language as important. The older children especially feel that learning Chinese is something they do because they have to obey their parents, but they do not think it is necessary or important. The question is then why the parents' positive attitudes are not transmitted to the second generation. The authors observe that for younger children, the activities they do in Chinese language school are regarded as fun, and they have enough free time to undertake them, since their academic activities in English are not too demanding. Also, younger children tend to spend more time with their parents, making exposure to the heritage language more natural. However, the enthusiasm for learning declines with age. According to the authors, starting with third graders the majority of children report that Chinese is hard to learn and the time allocated to learning Chinese takes up the time when they should be enjoying non-academic activities (Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009, p.88-89).

The authors' conclusion, which is similar to Tse (2000), Lee (2002) and Beckstead and Toribio (2003), is that the perception that their heritage language is 'useless' "...reveals a lack of support for HL learning in the mainstream American schools and in the larger society." The authors state that immigrant families alone cannot fight against the assimilative forces of English, and that "American mainstream schools should work together with immigrant parents and HL schools to incorporate children's HL in the official school curriculum and create a supportive environment for HL learning." (Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009, p.77).

Cherciov (2012) investigates the potential impact of language attitudes on first language attrition and second language acquisition among Romanian immigrants in Canada. According to the author, research on the influence of language attitudes on both L1 language attrition and L2 acquisition in bilinguals have often produced conflicting findings. Studies that use questionnaires as their main data collection

instrument mostly find no straight correlation between language attitudes and L1 performance, while studies that rely on interviews as their main data collection tool find clear links between the two (Cherciov, 2012, p.712). Cherciov proposes, then, a methodology that includes both instruments, questionnaires and an interview, as a means to establish a clearer picture of the influence of language attitudes on L1 and L2 performance. In her words, "...the richness of the migrant's experience cannot be reduced to a few constructs and generalizations, as made available by a questionnaire-based methodology. In this context, the use of questionnaires should be complemented with interviews, which provide the participants more control over the data revealed" (Cherciov, 2012, p.730).

Despite the fact that Cherciov's study does not deal with heritage speakers, her insights in terms of methodology are very significant to this study, since it follows her recommendation of a double methodological approach that relies both on questionnaires and on interviews to investigate possible correlations between oral proficiency, cultural practices and attitudes in heritage speakers. Another important insight from Cherciov's study is that many times bilinguals can have different attitudes towards their two languages and about bilingualism itself. In her study, she finds instances of migrants that do not have a particularly positive attitude towards Romanian, but do have very positive attitudes towards bilingualism itself (Cherciov, 2012, p.728). This finding supports the methodological choice of creating three separate topic areas for the language attitudes questionnaire used in this study: Portuguese, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US. More details about the three topic areas will be provided in chapter 3.

MacGregor-Mendoza (2015) investigates the linguistic attitudes and values held by female Mexican immigrants to the US who hold university degrees or have an even higher educational attainment, and who are married to partners with an equally high educational background. The author emphasizes the need for studies with this

demographic, observing that “Although still a fraction of the total immigration from Mexico, profesionistas (*professionals*) are becoming an increasingly important segment of the immigration stream, their presence having increased four-fold between 1990 and 2005.” (MacGregor-Mendoza, 2015, p.330). Citing Lambert and Taylor (1996), she observes that working-class families and middle-class families can have different attitudes and beliefs regarding bilingualism and biculturalism, and that no studies had been conducted about middle-class Mexican immigrants’ attitudes.

The informants in this study are 17 women who had arrived fairly recent in the US at the time of data collection (less than 10 years in the US), and, as mentioned, have a high degree of education, although many of them were not working at the time of data collection in order to take care of young children. These women are married to spouses with an equally high degree of education, making them members of the middle class in the US. The informants answered questionnaires and participated in an oral interview with the researcher. The questionnaires are designed to gather sociodemographic data about the participants and their families, information about their abilities in English and Spanish, as well as information about their language use in different communicative contexts and with different interlocutors, their attitudes, and their social network and social interactions. The interview’s goal is to collect further information about the circumstances of the informants’ immigration to the US, their experience living in a new country, their beliefs and attitudes. Participants were also asked about hopes, aspirations, and fears they have about their children.

The author observes that the informants’ sense of identity with Mexico has not been diminished in the time they have lived in the US, since they identify themselves and their husbands as “mexicanos.” Similarly, all informants are very confident about their language abilities in Spanish, with all classifying them as “excellent” in speaking, understanding, and reading, and all but one (who chose “well” as her answer) classifying them as “excellent” in writing. In English, however, most informants are

more confident about their passive abilities (reading and understanding) than about their active abilities (speaking and writing), despite the fact that their social position before immigration allowed them previous contact with English. Nonetheless, the author observes that most informants possessed at least a “fair” overall ability in English, which allowed them to access information and services that may be provided in the US only in English. In terms of language choice, the informants overwhelmingly indicate a preference for Spanish when interacting with their spouses and children. The author comments that while use of the heritage language at home is crucial for intergenerational transmission, many times it is not sufficient to guarantee language maintenance in a broader context. For this reason, she also investigates language choice in the families’ social networks. Her findings indicate that friends and family outside the immediate nuclear units collaborate in the retention and development of Spanish through frequent interactions in the language, which also helps to legitimize the use of Spanish in broader social contexts, instead of it being just the language of the home (MacGregor-Mendoza, 2015, p.337). The informants also report frequent trips to Mexico and frequent visits by Mexican relatives, which further helps with Spanish use and Spanish ability development and maintenance.

The author observes also that the informants’ efforts in transmitting their linguistic and cultural skills are not passive. They make an effort to create an environment that is conducive to Spanish maintenance, despite living in an English-dominant culture that does not place a lot of value in Spanish. (MacGregor-Mendoza, 2015, p.339). They intentionally teach Spanish to their children, correcting mistakes and insisting that the the kids speak their heritage language whenever possible. This group of informants, differently than what we see in the working-class informants from Lambert and Taylor (1996), do not see their own or their children’s acquisition of English as a prerequisite for social or financial advancement. “Instead, they regard their children’s learning English as a natural outcome of their present circumstances. With

regard to their own pursuit of better English skills, these informants expressed only that English would be an instrument to employ strategically to support their family's professional or educational endeavors" (MacGregor-Mendoza, 2015, p.341). These informants believe that a high degree of proficiency in both Spanish and English offers social, economic, and cultural advantages over mastering only one of these languages. In her conclusion, the author states that "similar to the distinct linguistic values held by working-class and middle-class Cubans (Lambert and Taylor 1996), social class may indeed be a factor in how Mexican immigrant families transmit linguistic and cultural skills and capital to their offspring" (MacGregor-Mendoza, 2015, p.345). This study, similar to Lambert and Taylor (1996), points to the potential role that parents' educational attainment can have on heritage speakers language choice.

Miller (2017) investigates how attitudes toward the minority language change with age in a group of young Spanish-English bilinguals, and the possible effects of these attitudes on language dominance and their heritage language proficiency. In Miller's words, and in consonance with Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe (2009) results mentioned in this chapter, "It is imperative that the field consider the importance of studying child attitudes toward minority languages due to the fact that their attitudes do not necessarily correlate with parental attitudes. If they do not, child attitudes may be a variable affecting minority language transmission, which is not yet fully understood. (Miller, 2017, p.103). In agreement with Oh and Au (2005), the author also observes that "While there is copious research on the effect of attitudes and motivation on second language acquisition (...), much of this knowledge has yet to be applied to heritage language or minority language acquisition" (Miller, 2017, p.99).

Miller's informants are 65 English-Spanish simultaneous bilingual children from the American Midwest. They come from two different English-only public elementary schools in the same state, and are divided by grade. All children share similar linguistic and socioeconomic profiles, and come from homes where Spanish is the primary

spoken language. The children completed all their schooling in the United States (Miller, 2017, p.107).

The informants completed two tasks aimed at uncovering their language attitudes and language preference. The first one was an interview about their heritage language in which they were asked “to attribute attitudes to their peers, their parents, their teachers and themselves as to the use of the minority language in various contexts. Responses are given on a three-point Likert scale accompanied with images of faces expressing various levels of approval or disapproval. (...) Specifically, a smiling face was intended to express positive attitudes, a face with a flat mouth to express ambivalence and a frowning face to express negative attitudes” (Miller, 2017, p.107-108). The second task was a matched guise, based on samples in English and Spanish. Four Mexican Spanish/American English bilingual speakers, two men and two women, were recorded reading the story *The Very Hungry Caterpillar*, once in Spanish and once in English, and the children “were informed that they had to try to guess what each person was like just by listening to how they talked.” (Miller, 2017, p.109). The author provided children with opposing pairs of adjectives, for instance “strong” and “weak”, or “intelligent” and “unintelligent”, that they should use to classify the speakers. To measure participants’ proficiency, the author used language proficiency scores as reported by the parents and the *Test de Vocabulario en Imágenes Peabody (TVIP)*, which is a standardized measure of children’s receptive vocabulary. The children are required to identify the correct picture out of four choices for each vocabulary item they hear. As the test progresses the frequency of the words declines based on word frequency lists in Spanish (Miller, 2017, p.110).

The study finds that participants in grade four show the strongest preference for English compared to the other age groups, while the youngest children, the first graders, do not show any preference for either language (the data from kindergarteners had to be excluded, since the number of informants was too small.) According to the

author, “As exposure to majority-language schooling increases, preference for English steadily grows until fifth grade, when we no longer see this pattern” (Miller, 2017, p.110). Miller also states that “children clearly feel that different people in their lives prefer them to speak different languages, meaning that children are aware of language preferences and their need to cater to these.” (Miller, 2017, p.112), and “...these children also clearly understand when, where and with whom it is appropriate to use each language even by the time they are in Kindergarten, evidenced by their strong preference for English in the classroom, Spanish at home and either one on the playground” (Miller, 2017, p.116). Interestingly, commenting on the results of the matching guide task, the author says that “elementary school students do not project negative attitudes onto the actual speakers of the language and only prefer English in terms of language use, not necessarily prestige” (Miller, 2017, p.116), which begs the question of when these language attitudes start to be attributed to actual speakers of the language. Unfortunately, the author does not further elaborate on the Spanish proficiency level of the informants, using that measure only to determine the relationship between language dominance and language attitudes, and commenting that “No significant correlation was found between minority language proficiency and language preference” (Miller, 2017, p.114).

In one of the few studies dealing with Portuguese immigrants, heritage speakers, and language attitudes, Gubitosi and de Oliveira (2020) analyze the relationship between language attitudes and language maintenance, using social networks as their frame of analysis. Their target population is two groups of European Portuguese speakers from the Fall River-New Bedford area in Massachusetts. The first group is comprised by 11 first generation immigrants from the island of Saint Michael (São Miguel), in the Azores, and the second group is formed by nine second generation, US-born children of immigrants from the same island. All participants self-identified as of “Portuguese origin”. The goal of the study is to compare the social networks,

language attitudes, and language usage of the two groups, and to investigate any possible impact of the speakers' social networks and language attitudes on language maintenance in the two groups. To gather data, the authors use both demographic and attitudinal questionnaires and a semi-structured sociolinguistic interview, which is consistent with the direction already appointed by Cherciov (2012) in terms of using multiple instruments in order to allow for a more complete picture of the influence of language attitudes on language maintenance and change. The study finds that the first and second generation speakers' social networks are not connected in the same way, and that there is great variability in terms of social networks and language use among second-generation speakers. However, the authors observe that "speakers of first and second generations have positive attitudes in regards to their minority language and claim to be highly proficient in Portuguese and as a result they were able to maintain a one-hour interview in Portuguese, regardless of their level of language proficiency." (Gubitosi and de Oliveira, 2020, p.30). In consonance with findings in other studies cited in this chapter, such as Mejías et al. (2003) and MacGregor-Mendoza (2015), the authors state that "there is a correlation between positive attitudes towards one's own minority language and language use in some domains. Thus, we conclude that linguistic attitudes continue to be a key factor in preventing language loss and promoting ethnic pride, which will ultimately benefit language maintenance" (Gubitosi and de Oliveira, 2020, p.31).

The studies discussed in this chapter show that language attitudes and cultural and linguistic practices, among other factors, can play a role on language choice, language maintenance and loss among immigrant groups, and on heritage language acquisition by heritage speakers. Many of these studies show that not just the heritage speakers' attitudes towards their heritage language are significant to language use and maintenance, but their parents' attitudes towards their native language also matter. Importantly, the larger community attitudes towards immigration, bilin-

gualism and minority languages are very important, at least as viewed by heritage speakers themselves. The picture is not as clear, though, when it comes to possible correlations between oral proficiency and attitudes, or between oral proficiency and cultural practices, in part because attitudes and cultural practices are sometimes conflated, as we saw, for instance, in Lee (2002) and Oh and Au (2005), and because of the different ways in which cultural practices are measured. Another issue that can be problematic, as we saw in Hakuta and D'andrea (1992) and Swender et al. (2014), is the tools and procedures used to assess oral proficiency. These two studies show that using self-assessment as a measure of proficiency for heritage speakers can produce unreliable results. However, some studies do rely on self-assessment as their only measure of proficiency, for instance Lee (2002). Finally, as Miller (2017) points out, studies that investigate correlations between language attitudes and proficiency in heritage speakers are still scarce. This study aims to address these issues. The next chapter presents the methodology and instruments used to gather data about attitudes and cultural practices, as well as the tools and rubrics used to assess oral proficiency.

CHAPTER 3

METHODOLOGY

The goal of this study is to investigate potential correlations among the oral proficiency of heritage speakers of Brazilian Portuguese (BP), their practices in relation to their heritage culture, and their attitudes towards their heritage language. This chapter describes the context of the study and its participants, the research questions it proposes to answer, the way in which each one of the variables is operationalized, and the instruments used to gather data.

3.1 Context of the study

The study was conducted with undergraduate students from the University of Massachusetts, Amherst, a public, 4-year institution that offers several courses in Portuguese language, linguistics, literature, and culture, and where students can pursue a major or minor in Portuguese. As mentioned in chapter 1, the state of Massachusetts, and New England in general, is home to significant Portuguese, Brazilian, and Cape Verdean immigrant communities, and there are many heritage speakers of Portuguese among the UMass Amherst student body. Recruitment for the project was done through advertising at the university, focusing specially on student organizations where BP speakers could be found, such as Latinos Unidos and the Lusophone Student Alliance. Among the ones who answered the call, 20 students matched the requirements of the study and were recruited to participate. More details about them will be provided in subsection 3.1.1.

The informants participated in a data collection session with the researcher, in which they performed five different tasks: 1) Fill out a background questionnaire designed to gather sociolinguistic data; 2) fill out a likert-scale questionnaire designed to gather information about their cultural practices related to their heritage culture; 3) fill out a likert-scale questionnaire designed to gauge their attitudes towards BP, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US; 4) fill out a likert-scale questionnaire in which they evaluate their own ability to perform certain communicative tasks in BP; 5) participate in an oral interview conducted by the researcher, which provided the data for the independent evaluation of their oral proficiency and for their attitudes. Sections 3.3, 3.4, 3.5, and 3.6 provide further details about each one of these tasks.

3.1.1 Participants

The participants in this study are 20 college students from UMass Amherst. They are all heritage speakers of BP, according to the definition mentioned in chapter 1: a person who was born in the US or who immigrated to the US before the age of 6, who is or was raised in a home where BP is spoken, and who is to some degree bilingual in BP and in English. In order to qualify to participate, they also had to meet the following criteria: 1) Be born in the United States or have arrived in the US before the age of 6. There is extensive debate about age of arrival issues when studying heritage speakers (for more details, see, for instance, Montrul (2008b)). For the purpose of this study, the age of arrival was limited to 6 in order to guarantee that the participants would have started their formal schooling in the United States, in English, and would have had little to no formal academic education in Brazil as kids, thus minimizing variation in formal education levels in BP during childhood among the participants. 2) Have at least one parent who is a native speaker of BP, and with whom the informant interacts in Portuguese, at least in some contexts (this

information was gathered through the sociolinguistic questionnaire). The goal of this condition is to guarantee that the informant has had sufficient levels of input in the heritage language to allow for some degree of oral proficiency in BP. 3) Be 18 years old or older.

The informants' ages vary between 18 and 22 (with the mean of 19.85). 12 of them identify as female, and eight identify as male. 16 of the informants were born in the US, while four were born in Brazil. Of these four, two arrived in the US at age five, one at age four, and one at age three (average age of arrival is 4.25). Table 3.1 summarizes this information.

Participant	Gender	Age	Country of birth	Age of arrival
1	female	21	US	
2	female	20	US	
3	male	18	US	
4	female	19	US	
5	male	19	US	
6	female	18	Brazil	4yo
7	female	20	Brazil	5yo
8	male	21	US	
9	male	22	US	
10	female	18	Brazil	5yo
11	female	18	Brazil	2.9yo
12	female	19	US	
13	female	20	US	
14	male	21	US	
15	male	22	US	
16	male	19	US	
17	female	21	US	
18	male	22	US	
19	female	20	US	
20	female	19	US	

Table 3.1. Participants' background information

As we can see in table 3.2, 15 of the informants have both parents born in Brazil, while five have only one parent born in Brazil. Among the ones with one parent born in Brazil, two have a parent born in the USA (the father in both cases), who are native speakers of English, one in Portugal (the father), who is a native speaker of European Portuguese, one in Cape Verde (the mother), who is a native speaker of

Cape Verdean Creole, and one in Suriname (the mother), who is a native speaker of Dutch.¹

Participant	Lang. parent 1	Lang. parent 2
1	BP	BP
2	CVC	BP
3	BP	Dutch
4	BP	BP
5	BP	BP
6	BP	BP
7	BP	BP
8	BP	BP
9	EP	BP
10	BP	BP
11	BP	BP
12	BP	BP
13	BP	BP
14	BP	BP
15	BP	BP
16	BP	BP
17	English	BP
18	English	BP
19	BP	BP
20	BP	BP

Table 3.2. Languages spoken by participants' parents

Participant	Residence
1	Newton, MA
2	New Bedford, MA
3	Swampscott, MA
4	Marshfield, MA
5	Harrison, NY
6	Templeton, MA
7	Revere, MA
8	Medford, MA
9	Marlborough, MA
10	Shrewsbury, MA
11	Malden, MA
12	Marion, MA
13	Boston, MA
14	Marlborough, MA
15	Boston, MA
16	Hudson, MA
17	Brooklyn, NY
18	Amherst, MA
19	Lancaster, MA
20	White Plains, NY

Table 3.3. Participants' place of residence

¹BP = Brazilian Portuguese, CVC = Cape Verdean Creole, EP = European Portuguese.

Out of the 20 informants, 17 indicate that their hometown in the US is in the state of Massachusetts, while three list hometowns in the state of New York. Table 3.3 shows participants places of residence in the US.

As mentioned in chapter 1, these two states are, respectively, the second and the fifth with the highest number of Brazilian immigrants in the United States. Within these two states, Brazilian communities are concentrated in the metropolitan areas of Boston and New York City.

Out of the three informants from New York state, one comes from Brooklyn, in New York City, one from White Plains, which is an outer suburb of New York City located in Westchester county, and one from Harrison, another New York City suburb located in Westchester county.

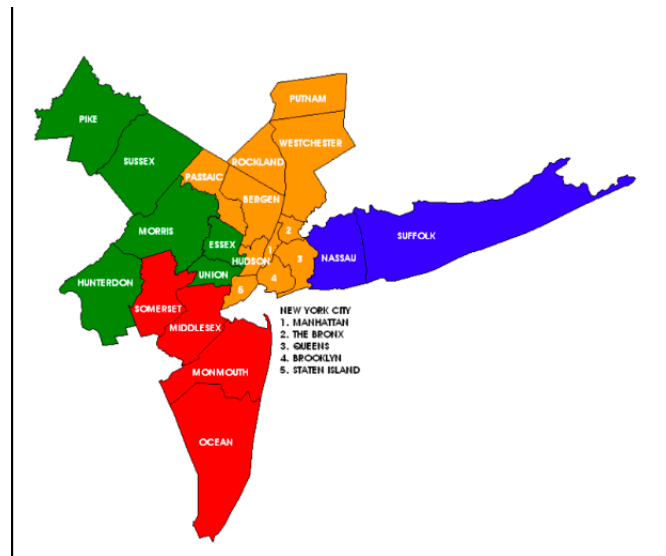


Figure 3.1. NYC metro area counties

In Massachusetts, out of the 17 informants, the majority comes from the Eastern part of the state, within the Greater Boston metropolitan area. Two come from Boston itself, and a third comes from Revere, which is located in the same county as Boston, Suffolk. Five come from Middlesex county, from the towns of Newton, Medford, Marlborough (2 people), Malden, and Hudson. These towns are considered

by many as suburbs of Boston, since several people live there, but work in Boston. One other informant comes from Swampscott, in Essex county, another area close to Boston, in the North Shore. Two informants come from Marshfield and Marion, two towns in Plymouth county, located to the south of Boston.

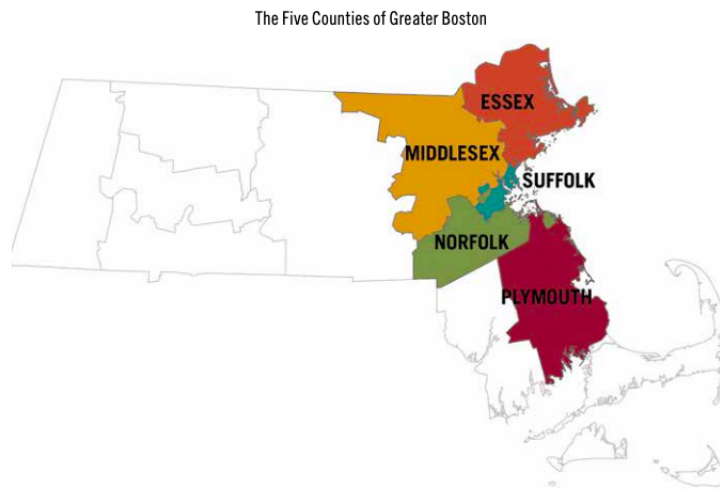


Figure 3.2. Boston metro area counties

Out of the remaining informants, three come from Worcester county, in the Central part of the state, from the towns of Shrewsbury, Templeton, and Lancaster.

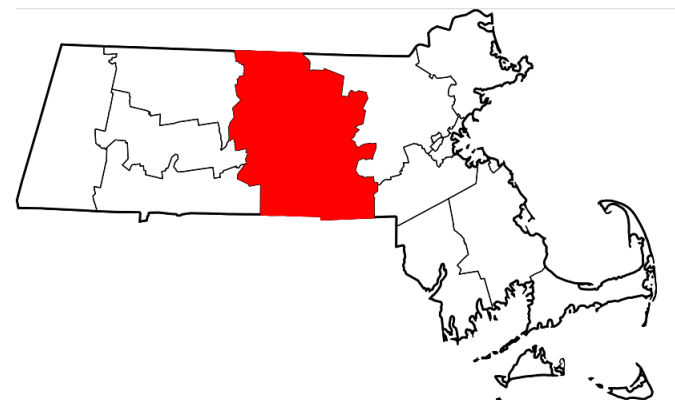


Figure 3.3. Worcester county

Finally, one informant only comes from the Western part of the state, from Amherst, the same town where UMass Amherst is located.

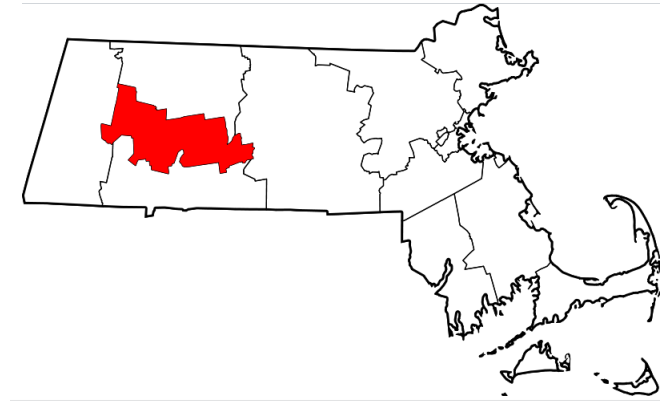


Figure 3.4. Hampshire county

This geographic distribution means that some of the informants come from communities in which it can be easier or harder to be exposed to BP and to the Brazilian culture in general. In order to gather information about the communities from which the informants come, I included in the oral interview a question that asked them to talk about their level of contact with Brazilians in their hometown in the US.

In the case of New York state, all three informants come from the area of the state where the Brazilian population is concentrated. The participant from Harrison says that when he was a child he had contact with many other people who came from the same city as his parents, Belo Horizonte, in the state of Minas Gerais, Brazil, but that now he does not have a lot of contact with Brazilians in his town anymore. The participant from Brooklyn says she does not feel very connected with the Brazilian culture, despite being very proud of her Brazilian heritage, and does not have contact with many Brazilians outside of her family. The third informant from New York state, who is from White Plains, says that she has contact with many Brazilians in her hometown, and the community is big, but they not always speak Portuguese when

they are together. She adds “with some of my Brazilian friends I speak in Portuguese, but with others I speak in English. It depends on where and with whom I am.”

As for Massachusetts, the Western part of the state does not count with a very significant Brazilian community, and it is not very common to hear BP spoken in the towns and cities in this part of the state. The sole informant from Western Massachusetts confirmed this in the oral interview. When asked about the Brazilian community in his hometown in the US, he said “I had contact with a few Brazilians when I was in school, but I did not speak Portuguese with them.” As for the Central part of the state, the situation is more mixed. Some cities, like Worcester, for instance, do have small but significant Brazilian communities, but not all towns in the county have many BP speakers. The informant from Templeton says “I don’t know many Brazilians in my town, it’s a very small place.” The informant from Lancaster, on the other hand, says “In my area there are many Brazilian bakeries and supermarkets.” Talking about her church, she continues “In my church we always have celebrations, like Father’s day, for instance, which is different in Brazil and here, it’s in August.” She adds that her church in her hometown is what has allowed her to be a part of the Brazilian culture, since she has never had the chance to travel to Brazil. The informant from Shrewsbury says that in her hometown there were not many Brazilians in the past, but this number is growing: “In my high school class there were maybe six Brazilians among 450 students, but in the last two years I became part of a group that helps new students in my town, and there are many Brazilians now.”

As we can see, the participants’ perceptions about their communities of origin in the US are very heterogeneous, and in order to find out more about these communities and investigate the relationships between the informants’ place of origin in the US and their level of oral proficiency in BP, it would be necessary to conduct an in-depth ethnographic study, which is out of the scope of this dissertation.

Of all informants, only two reported studying Portuguese formally in school in the US before college. One of them attended a bilingual English/Portuguese program in elementary school between kindergarten and third grade, plus four years of Portuguese as a foreign language classes in high school. The other informant took seven years of Portuguese as a foreign language courses in middle and high school. Both informants completed their elementary and secondary education in Massachusetts. As the data in chapter 4 will show, however, the previous years of formal education in Portuguese did not translate into higher oral proficiency levels in the case of these two participants.

At the moment of data collection, 14 of the informants had taken at least one course in the Portuguese program at UMass Amherst, while six had not taken any classes at all. as we can see in table 3.4.

Participant	Portuguese course in college
1	yes
2	yes
3	yes
4	no
5	yes
6	no
7	no
8	yes
9	yes
10	no
11	no
12	no
13	yes
14	yes
15	yes
16	yes
17	yes
18	yes
19	yes
20	yes

Table 3.4. Participants and college courses taken

Of the 14 who took at least one course, only one participant was placed in an intermediate level Portuguese class, while all the others were placed in advanced courses. It is important to note that UMass Amherst does not offer Portuguese language classes specifically designed for heritage speakers, so these heritage speakers

were in classes that are also open to foreign language learners. Interestingly, as we will also see in chapter 4, the informants who had not taken any classes at UMass by the point of data collection had higher degrees of oral proficiency in BP than the ones who had taken at least one course by the point of data collection.

Table 3.5 summarizes all the information about the participants

Participant	Gender	Age	Country of birth	Age of arrival	Residence	Lang. parent 1	Lang. parent 2	College course
1901	female	21	US		Newton, MA	BP	BP	yes
1902	female	20	US		New Bedford, MA	CVC	BP	yes
1903	male	18	US		Swampscott, MA	BP	Dutch	yes
1904	female	19	US		Marshfield, MA	BP	BP	no
1905	male	19	US		Harrison, NY	BP	BP	yes
1906	female	18	Brazil	4yo	Templeton, MA	BP	BP	no
1907	female	20	Brazil	5yo	Revere, MA	BP	BP	no
1908	male	21	US		Medford, MA	BP	BP	yes
1909	male	22	US		Marlborough, MA	EP	BP	yes
1910	female	18	Brazil	5yo	Shrewsbury, MA	BP	BP	no
1911	female	18	Brazil	2.9yo	Malden, MA	BP	BP	no
1912	female	19	US		Marion, MA	BP	BP	no
1913	female	20	US		Boston, MA	BP	BP	yes
1914	male	21	US		Marlborough, MA	BP	BP	yes
2101	male	22	US		Boston, MA	BP	BP	yes
2102	male	19	US		Hudson, MA	BP	BP	yes
2103	female	21	US		Brooklyn, NY	English	BP	yes
2104	male	22	US		Amherst, MA	English	BP	yes
2105	female	20	US		Lancaster, MA	BP	BP	yes
2106	female	19	US		White Plains, NY	BP	BP	yes

Table 3.5. Participants data summarized

3.2 Research questions and hypotheses

The overarching research question in this study is: Are there correlations among the oral proficiency of heritage speakers of Brazilian Portuguese (BP), their practices in relation to their heritage culture, and their attitudes towards their heritage language, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US? As mentioned in chapter 1, should research findings point to specific correlations between higher oral proficiency in the heritage language and certain attitudes or cultural practices, this information can be used to find new ways to promote bilingualism and language maintenance among heritage populations.

In this study, the above overarching question is broken down into three more specific ones. The research questions and hypotheses for this study are detailed below:

Research question 1: Is there a correlation between the *oral proficiency* of heritage speakers and their *cultural practices*?

Hypothesis:

- A higher *cultural practices* score will correlate to a higher *oral proficiency* level in heritage speakers of BP, while a lower *cultural practices* score will correlate to a lower *oral proficiency* level in heritage speakers of BP.

Research question 2: Is there a correlation between the *oral proficiency* of heritage speakers and their *positive attitudes* towards their heritage language, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US?

Hypothesis:

- A higher *positive attitudes* score will correlate to a higher *oral proficiency* level in heritage speakers of BP, while a lower *positive attitudes* score will correlate to a lower *oral proficiency* level in heritage speakers of BP.

Research question 3: Is there a correlation between the *oral proficiency* of heritage speakers and their *negative attitudes* towards their heritage language, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US?

Hypothesis:

- A higher *negative attitudes* score will correlate to a lower *oral proficiency* level in heritage speakers of BP, while a lower *negative attitudes* score will correlate to a higher *oral proficiency* level in heritage speakers of BP.

In order to answer these research questions and test these hypotheses, the first step is to operationalize the variables observed in the study. The four main variables

are: *oral proficiency*, *cultural practices*, *positive attitudes*, and *negative attitudes*. In each of the sections below, we see how they are conceived and operationalized. It is important to highlight that due to the nature of variables related to cultural practices and attitudes, the way the researcher decides to implement them can have a significant impact on the data, the results, and the analysis proposed. In each of the sections below, we see the choices made in the operationalization of the variables, the instruments used to collect data, and the data coding mechanisms.

3.3 Oral proficiency

The first step that needs to be taken in a study evaluating proficiency is to determine how to measure it. Especially in a study whose target population is heritage speakers, it is very important to specify the measures and rubrics being used, since there is no consensus in the field about how to evaluate levels of proficiency in this population. This study's methodological choice was to assess the informants' oral communication abilities using a functional scale that foregoes detailed analyses of grammatical accuracy, vocabulary appropriateness, or quality of accent, which are measures of proficiency used in other studies presented in chapter 2. Instead, the option in this study is to analyze the informants' ability to undertake specific communicative functions in their heritage language, such as formulate hypotheses or narrate in the past.

The choice of a functional scale aims to avoid a common issue pointed out by several authors, most notably (Valdés, 1989), which is how to appropriately evaluate proficiency levels in heritage speakers. Some studies have shown that in specific contexts it is possible to use proficiency measurements designed for second language learners for heritage speakers. For instance, Kagan and Friedman (2003) show that,

for college educated heritage speakers of Russian, using the ACTFL OPI interview², together with its assessment criteria, is effective and accurate due to the particular characteristics of this group of speakers. However, as we mentioned in chapter 1, heritage speakers are by definition a very heterogeneous group, and using rubrics and measures designed for second language learners might not be appropriate for all subgroups within the vast universe of heritage speakers. Many times the standard against which one measures proficiency in second language learners is the educated native speaker, who went through several years of formal education in their native language and is fluent, both in writing and speaking, in a prestige dialect of their native language. A second language learner usually acquires the target language also through formal education, and is consequently exposed to a prestige or an academic variety of this language. It makes sense, then, that the standard used to evaluate these learners should be the educated native speaker. When it comes to heritage speakers, however, the situation is more complex. While it is true that many of them do have the opportunity to study their heritage language in a formal academic setting, it is also true that not all of them do, and the ones who do not go through some kind of formal training may be exposed only to a very informal variety of their heritage language or to dialects that do not carry social prestige or are considered non-standard. That does not mean, however, that they are not able to communicate effectively in their heritage language, and any study that uses heritage speakers as its target population needs to take into consideration the particular characteristics of

²The OPI (Oral Proficiency Interview) is the main instrument used by ACTFL (American Council on the Teaching of Foreign Languages) to evaluate foreign language learners' oral abilities. It consists of a face-to-face or telephone interview between a certified examiner and the examinee. The interviewer asks the interviewee a series of personalized questions formulated to allow the interviewer to establish "a clear floor and ceiling of consistent functional ability." The recorded interview is then rated by one or more certified examiners using a proficiency scale developed by ACTFL in 2012. For more information about the OPI and ACTFL proficiency levels, visit <http://www.actfl.org/professional-development/certified-proficiency-testing-program/testing-proficiency> and <https://www.actfl.org/publications/guidelines-and-manuals/actfl-proficiency-guidelines-2012>.

these speakers in order to accurately assess their proficiency levels. In the particular case of the informants used in this study, the great majority of them (18 out of 20) did not have any formal education in BP before starting college.

With this functional scale this study hopes to offer a contribution to the field of heritage language studies in the form of an assessment instrument that can include all profiles of heritage speakers and does not run the risk of discriminating against the ones who might be able to use the heritage language very effectively, despite not having any or much formal instruction in it and perhaps speaking a variety of the heritage language that does not carry social prestige.

3.3.1 Operationalizing Oral proficiency

As mentioned in chapter 2, other studies have sought to find a correlation between proficiency in the heritage language, attitudes, and cultural practices. However, some of them use self-assessment as their only measure of proficiency. As we saw in chapters 1 and 2, though, there are at least two studies that report discrepancies between self-assessed and independently assessed oral proficiency in heritage speakers (Hakuta and D'andrea, 1992; Swender et al., 2014). For this reason, besides a self-evaluation by the informants, in this study two native speakers of BP³ perform an independent evaluation of each one of the oral interviews using a functional scale that mirrors the one used by the informants for their self-assessment. Both evaluation rubrics can be found below in subsections 3.3.2 and 3.3.3.⁴ Using this double measure this study aims to obtain a more reliable evaluation of the informants oral proficiency, and at the same time address a question that, although not central to the purpose of this study,

³Even though I am a native speaker of BP, I am not one of the evaluators. Since I collected all the data, including the oral interview, I did not want to run the risk of letting my previous impressions of the participants have any bearings on their oral proficiency independent evaluations.

⁴I would like to thank Prof. Gláucia Silva for her help and suggestions about the oral proficiency scale.

may help to further clarify the issue of the reliability of self-evaluations as a measure of proficiency in heritage speakers. Is there a correlation between the informants' self-assessed level of oral proficiency and their independently assessed level of oral proficiency in BP?

3.3.2 Oral proficiency data collection - self-assessed

In order to evaluate their own oral proficiency in BP, informants were asked to fill out a likert-scale questionnaire measuring how well they could perform different communicative functions in Portuguese. The questionnaire is comprised of 11 statements, each one corresponding to specific communicative function: Describe oneself and people close to you; describe your daily life and routines; describe pictures of people performing everyday activities; narrate in the past; compare two opposite options; talk about hypothetical situations in the present; make predictions about the future; give advice; talk about hypothetical situations in the past; talk about abstract topics. The answers measured their opinion about their ability to fulfill these specific communicative tasks, and the likert-scale options were: Not at all; Poorly; Reasonably well; Well; Very well. The informants filled out this questionnaire before doing the oral interview in which they would be asked to actually perform these communicative tasks, so that the interview would not interfere with their previous opinion about their abilities. The 11 statements are listed below:

Self-assessed Oral Proficiency Questionnaire

1. I can describe myself, my family and my friends.
2. I can describe my typical day at work or school.
3. I can describe images of people performing different activities.
4. I can talk about my last vacation, for example, describing things that I did, places I visited, etc.

5. I can discuss the advantages and disadvantages of two opposing options. For instance: working from home vs. working in an office.
6. I can talk about a nice trip that I took.
7. I can talk about how I imagine my life and the world in the future.
8. I can formulate hypotheses. For instance, what I would do if I were the president of the US.
9. I can give advice to a friend. For instance, to someone who is having family problems.
10. I can talk about what I would have done if I were in the place of somebody who had a problem. For instance, a student who forgot to turn in a paper before the deadline.
11. I can talk about abstract topics. For instance, vegetarianism or veganism vs. more traditional diets.

3.3.3 Oral proficiency data collection - independently-assessed

To provide the data used in the independently assessed oral proficiency, informants were asked to participate in an oral interview conducted by the researcher. The interview was recorded and subsequently analyzed by two native speakers of BP, who conducted the independent oral proficiency evaluation. The two evaluators also have experience interacting with heritage speakers and assessing their oral production. Prior to analyzing the data, the two graders went through a training session using previously recorded interviews, to calibrate their assessment standards.

The interview questions were designed to gather input about the same communicative functions listed above in subsection 3.3.2: Describe oneself and people close to you; describe your daily life and routines; describe pictures of people performing everyday activities; narrate in the past; compare two opposite options; talk about hypothetical situations in the present; make predictions about the future; give advice;

talk about hypothetical situations in the past; talk about abstract topics. The order in which the questions were asked was always the same, and the interviews typically lasted between 15 and 20 minutes, although one particularly loquacious participant gave a 42 minute long interview, and a very quiet one a 11 minute long interview. In order to capture speech that was as spontaneous as possible in a situation where speakers know they are being recorded, no time limits were imposed, and the participants could speak freely for as long as they wanted or could after each question. All participants were able to maintain the conversation until the end of the interview, albeit with significant differences in terms of the amount of speech they produced and the easiness with which they answered the questions.

Besides serving as the source of data for communicative function number 11 (talk about abstract topics), questions 11, 12, 13, and 14 were also designed to gather information about implicit attitudes speakers hold about Brazilian Portuguese, being bilingual and bicultural, and about immigration in the US. As detailed below in section 3.5.1, this study uses both a questionnaire and an interview to collect data about attitudes, with the questionnaire designed to gather more explicit attitudes and the interview designed to elicit more implicit attitudes. The oral interview questions are below, and the pictures used in questions three and 10 can be found in the appendix.

Oral Interview Questions

1. Me fale um pouco sobre você e a sua família. (Tell me about yourself and your family).
2. Como é a sua rotina em um dia típico de trabalho (ou estudo)? (How is your typical day at work or school?)
3. Descreva as pessoas nesta foto. O que elas estão fazendo? (Describe the people in this picture. What are they doing?)

4. O que você fez nas suas últimas férias? (What did you do on your last vacation?)
5. Na sua opinião, é melhor morar em uma cidade grande ou em uma cidade pequena? Por quê? (In your opinion, is it better to live in a big city or in a small town? Why?)
6. Imagine que você ganhou 50 milhões de dólares na loteria. O que você faria? (Imagine you won 50 million dollars in the lottery. What would you do with the money?)
7. Fale sobre alguma viagem ou passeio interessante que você fez. (Tell me about an important trip or outing in your life.)
8. Imagine a sua vida e o mundo daqui a 20 anos. Como você acha que vai ser? (Imagine your life and the world in 20 years. How do you think it's going to be?)
9. Imagina que um amigo ou amiga está tendo problemas com o namorado ou namorada e te pede ajuda. Que conselhos você vai dar para ele ou ela? (Imagine a friend of yours is having problems with their significant other, and asks for your advice. What kind of advice would you give them?)
10. Imagine-se no lugar dessas pessoas. Isso aconteceu ontem com elas. O que você teria feito? (Imagine you were in these people's place. This happened to them yesterday. What would you have done?)
11. Me fala um pouco sobre a sua relação com o Brasil, a cultura brasileira e a língua portuguesa. (Tell me about your relationship with Brazil, Brazilian culture, and Portuguese.)
12. Você tem contato com outros brasileiros na sua cidade de origem? Como é essa comunidade? (Do you have contact with other Brazilians in your place of origin here? How is this community?)

13. Como você se sente falando português em público? O que você acha que as pessoas a seu redor estão pensando? (How do you feel when you speak Portuguese in public? What do you think the people around you are thinking?)
14. Qual é a sua opinião sobre a situação atual dos imigrantes nos EUA? (What is your opinion about the current situation of immigrants in the US?)

After the end of the data collection process, the recorded interview was analyzed by the two graders, using a functional questionnaire that mirrors the one used by the informants to self-assess their oral proficiency levels. By using parallel questionnaires, it is possible to perform comparable evaluations, with the only difference being that one is a self-assessment, and the other one is independent. The likert-scale evaluators used to assess the participants performance was the same as the one used by the informants when doing their self-assessment: Not at all; Poorly; Reasonably well; Well; Very well.

Independently Assessed Oral Proficiency Questionnaire

1. The participant can describe themselves, their family and friends.
2. The participant can describe their typical day at work or school.
3. The participant can describe images of people performing different activities.
4. The participant can talk about their last vacation, for example, describing things that they did, places they visited, etc.
5. The participant can discuss the advantages and disadvantages of two opposing options. For instance: working from home vs. working in an office, or living in a big city vs. living in a small town.
6. The participant can talk about a nice trip they took.

7. The participant can talk about how they imagine their life and the world in the future.
8. The participant can formulate hypotheses. For instance, what they would do if they were the president of the US, or what they would do if they won 50 million dollars in the lottery.
9. The participant can give advice to a friend. For instance, to someone who is having family problems or problems in their romantic relationship.
10. The participant can talk about what they would have done if they were in the place of somebody who had a problem. For instance, a student who forgot to turn in a paper before the deadline.
11. The participant can talk about abstract topics. For instance, vegetarianism or veganism vs. more traditional diets, or the immigration issue in the US.

3.3.4 Coding - Oral proficiency

After the end of the data collection process, the number of points for each participant was added, both for the self-assessment and the independent assessment. The likert-scale choices were: Not at all = 1 point; Poorly = 2 points; Reasonably well = 3 points; Well = 4 points; Very well = 5 points. The maximum number of points an informant could get for each one of the assessments was 55, and the minimum number of points was 11. In the case of the self-assessed proficiency level, the *Self-assessed proficiency* score was obtained by simply adding the points obtained for each statement. The results can be found in chapter 4. For the independent assessment, each grader evaluated the participants separately, giving each one of them a total score obtained by adding the points they received for each statement. The two graders' scores were then added and averaged, resulting in an *Independently assessed proficiency* score for each informant. The results are discussed in chapter 4.

3.4 Cultural practices

The variable *Cultural practices* in this study refers to everyday practices in which heritage speakers get the opportunity to be exposed to and interact with their heritage culture and language. Examples of these activities would be participating in celebrations particular to the heritage culture or listening to music in the heritage language. Most people would intuitively assume that more engagement with the heritage culture and language will correlate to a higher proficiency level in the heritage language, and in fact some studies do find such correlation (Lee, 2002; Oh and Au, 2005). However, these studies operationalize cultural practice in subjective ways, relying on informants' reported feelings, as we will see in section 3.4.1. This study employs more objective ways to measure cultural practices, so that the possible correlation between this variable and oral proficiency can be more transparent.

3.4.1 Operationalizing Cultural practices

As mentioned in chapter 2 and in section 3.4, previous studies point to significant correlations between oral proficiency in heritage speakers and their cultural practices in relation to their heritage culture. For instance, in a study of heritage speakers of Korean, Lee (2002) finds a correlation between self-assessed proficiency in the heritage language and an index of biculturalism, measured through a questionnaire mixing cultural practices and attitudes statements. Oh and Au (2005) show a correlation between one independently assessed measure of oral proficiency (nativeness of accent in the heritage language) and cultural identification and participation in Latino culture for heritage speakers of Spanish. In both studies, the cultural practices variable is measured through statements that involve identification with feelings; for instance, "I like to eat Korean food" (Lee (2002) p.126) or "I like meeting and getting to know people of Latino background." (Oh and Au (2005) p.233). However, the fact that a heritage speaker likes to eat Korean food or enjoys meeting Latino people does not

specify how often they actually engage in these activities, which could contribute to a higher exposure to the heritage language and culture and thus potentially correlate with their degree of proficiency in the heritage language. For this reason, in this study the cultural practices variable is assessed through a frequency scale, in which informants need to identify the frequency with which they participate in certain cultural practices. The activities are expressed through nine different statements, which can be found below in subsection 3.4.2. To answer, informants used a likert-scale whose options are: Never, Rarely, Sometimes, Often, and Very frequently.

3.4.2 Cultural practices data collection

Cultural Practices Questionnaire

1. I eat Brazilian food.
2. I listen to Brazilian music.
3. I watch Brazilian movies and/or TV shows.
4. I read Internet websites in Portuguese.
5. I keep up with current events in Brazil through Internet sites and/or Brazilian TV.
6. I keep in touch with my family and friends through social networks and/or text messages in Portuguese.
7. I speak Portuguese with my Brazilian and/or Brazilian-American friends.
8. My family and I keep at least some Brazilian cultural habits and traditions.
9. I travel to Brazil during vacations.

3.4.3 Coding - Cultural practices

The statements used measured the frequency with which participants engaged in certain activities. For coding purposes, each option corresponded to a certain number of points, varying from 1 to 5: Never = 1 point; Rarely = 2 points; Sometimes =

3 points; Often = 4 points; Very frequently = 5 points. There were 9 statements in total, so the maximum number of points a participant could get was 45, and the minimum was 9. After the end of the data collection process, the points for each one of the participants were added, resulting in their *Cultural Practices* score.

3.5 Attitudes

As mentioned in chapter 1, language attitudes can be defined as “a construct underlying the feelings people have about their own language and the language of others” (Crystal, 1992, p.215). As (Garrett, 2010, p.19) points out, on the surface this concept may seem simple, but it is in fact a complex one, given its many components and aspects. Two main theoretical approaches have been used when studying attitudes. The first one follows a behaviorist view, according to which attitudes should be studied by observing reactions and responses to certain languages. In other words, in order to study language attitudes, one should observe actual interactions (Appel and Muysken, 1987, p.16). This approach poses serious practical difficulties to the study of attitudes, since researchers need to either create experimental situations in which the attitudes being studied can be elicited or, even more complicated, identify situations in which these interactions occur naturally and find ethically appropriate ways to observe them.

The second approach follows a mentalist view, which considers attitudes as “an internal, mental state, which may give rise to certain forms of behavior” (Appel and Muysken, 1987, p.16). Crystal’s definition of attitude mentioned above follows this second approach, and it is the one used in this study. The mentalist approach allows for more easily implementable methodological designs, since these feelings that people have about their own language or the language of others can be elicited through questionnaires and interviews. It is true that in both the questionnaire and the interview we are only able to collect the responses that the informants choose to

share, that is to say, overt attitudes. It is also true that informants may choose, conscious or unconsciously, to mask or misrepresent their own attitudes, especially if these attitudes do not seem to be the “correct” ones in the view of the broader society or the social group to which the informant belongs or aspires to belong. One way to mitigate this issue is to use multiple instruments to elicit attitudes; for instance, questionnaires and interviews, as it is the case in this study. The questionnaire gathers attitudes in a more direct way, while the interview can detect further nuance in the informants’ attitudes.

As we saw in chapter 2, previous studies show correlations between attitudes and language choice, use, and maintenance. For instance, Hakuta and D’andrea (1992) finds a correlation between attitudes and language choice in bilingual Spanish-English high school students in California. Mejías et al. (2003) show that positive attitudes towards Spanish contribute to its maintenance in the Lower Rio Grande Valley region of Texas, while Gubitosi and de Oliveira (2020) show that positive attitudes contribute to the maintenance of Portuguese among Portuguese immigrants and heritage speakers in the Fall River-Bedford area in Massachusetts. Outside North America, a recent study with heritage speakers of Brazilian Portuguese has found that parental attitudes and expectations correlate with higher self-reported rates of heritage language (BP) use for their children. Shirakawa (2020) investigate the rates of use at home of Brazilian Portuguese and Japanese in school-age children who come from Brazilian immigrant parents living in Japan. The study finds that parental expectations and attitudes correlate to heritage language use at home for their school-age children; the higher their parents’ expectations for their levels of Portuguese proficiency, the higher the parent-reported rates of BP use at home.

However, the picture is not as clear when it comes to possible correlations between oral proficiency in the heritage language and attitudes in heritage speakers. As (Miller, 2017, p.99) points out, there is a lot of research done about how attitudes

correlate to second language acquisition, but not so much to heritage or minority language acquisition. This study aims to start filling this void, and it hypothesizes that attitudes do correlate with oral proficiency. More specifically, a high score for positive attitudes will correlate to a higher level of oral proficiency in the heritage language, while a high score for negative attitudes will correlate to a lower level of oral proficiency in the heritage language.

3.5.1 Operationalizing Attitudes

When operationalizing the attitudes variable, three important questions need to be addressed. The first one has to do with the evaluation instruments used for measuring it. Some attitudes studies use questionnaires as their main method of data collection, while others use interviews. However, as (Cherciov, 2012, p.730) notes, there is no consensus about the best methodology, and, depending on the method used, different studies tend to reach different conclusions about the influence of attitudes in both second language acquisition and first language attrition. Her suggestion is that a mixed approach, with both questionnaires and interviews might be the best solution, and this study uses this methodology. The questionnaires provides more easily quantifiable data, which can be used in quantitative analyses, while the interview can elicit more spontaneous participants' attitudes data that can be used in qualitative analyses. As we will see in chapter 4, the *Attitudes* score, described in this section, is used in the quantitative analysis to directly answer research questions number two and three, while some data from the interviews is used in chapter 5 to qualitatively analyze the individual attitudes of some participants.

The second question to be addressed relates to the potentially different impact that negative and positive attitudes can have on oral proficiency levels. While it is true that both positive and negative attitudes could directly correlate to the participants' oral proficiency, it is also possible that only one of them (or neither of them) does. In fact,

Cunha (2019) showed a higher probability of a correlation between oral proficiency and negative attitudes than between oral proficiency and positive attitudes. For this reason, the language attitudes questionnaire in this study contains both negative and positive attitudes statements, for which separate statistical analyses are run, resulting in a *positive attitudes* score and a *negative attitudes* score for each of the informants.

The third question is related to the content of the attitudes statements analyzed. As we will see in more detail in section 3.5.2, there are three separate attitudinal topics being analyzed: (i) Brazilian Portuguese itself, (ii) bilingualism and biculturalism, and (iii) immigration in the US. While it is possible that participants have similar attitudes about the three topics, it may also be the case that they are different. In fact, (Cherciov, 2012, p.728) mention that bilinguals may sometimes have different attitudes towards their particular non-dominant language and towards bilingualism itself, and (Mejías et al., 2003, p.148) show that some types of attitudes can contribute more to language maintenance among bilinguals than others, which makes it clear that the separation into topics might be an important methodological tool.⁵

3.5.2 Attitudes data collection

To gather data about attitudes, the participants were asked to fill out a questionnaire comprised of 18 statements. As mentioned in subsection 3.5.1, half the statements express positive attitudes and half negative attitudes about each of the three topic areas specified above. The likert-scale used to answer has the following options: Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, and Strongly agree. It is important to provide informants with a neutral option (neither agree nor disagree) to avoid forcing them into taking a position about a statement they are unsure about, since this could artificially inflate either their positive or negative atti-

⁵I would like to thank Prof. Talia Bugel and Prof. Patricia Gubitosi for their help in refining the attitudes statements.

tudes score. When participating in the data collection session, the informants did not see the statements separated into positive and negative or into topic areas. Instead, they saw one questionnaire that mixed the positive and negative statements, as well as the topic areas, in a random order. To make the data collection mechanism more transparent, below we see the statements separated into positive and negative, and by topic area. The complete questionnaire used by the informants can be found in the appendix.

Positive attitudes statements

Positive statements about the language (Brazilian Portuguese)

1. Portuguese is a beautiful language.
2. I am proud of my ability to speak Portuguese and of my Brazilian heritage.
3. Knowing Portuguese helps me or will help me in the future with my professional life.

Positive statements about bilingualism and biculturalism

1. Being bicultural and bilingual is in many aspects an advantage to me.
2. All immigrant parents should teach their native language to their US-born children.
3. A person loses an important part of their identity when they do not have contact with their parents' language and culture.

Positive statements about immigration

1. Immigrants make important contributions to their communities in the US.
2. Being a child of immigrants and being bilingual and bicultural make my life richer.
3. Immigration is a positive thing, and it has always been what defines the US as a country.

Negative attitudes statements

Negative statements about the language (Brazilian Portuguese)

1. So far, I do not think knowing Portuguese has brought me many benefits or advantages.
2. The energy and time necessary to keep my Portuguese knowledge are too great, and the benefits of knowing it too small.
3. It is not crucial for me to learn Portuguese or maintain my Portuguese knowledge because I live in the U.S.

Negative statements about bilingualism and biculturalism

1. It is easier for a monolingual English speaker to be more successful than a person who speaks another language besides English in the US.
2. It is better to speak only English with my family when we are in public spaces.
3. Speaking another language had or can have a negative impact on my ability to speak English well.

Negative statements about immigration

1. Immigrants should not have the same rights and benefits as US-born citizens.
2. Immigration creates more problems and conflicts in the US than benefits to the country.
3. Being a child of immigrants has made my life in the US harder than the lives of my friends who are not children of immigrants.

3.5.3 Coding - Attitudes

The following scores were attributed to each of the possible answers mentioned in subsection 3.5.2: Strongly disagree = 1 point, Disagree = 2 points, Neither agree nor disagree = 3 points, Agree = 4 points, and Strongly agree = 5 points. After the end of the data collection process, the points for the positive and negative statements

were added separately, resulting in a *Positive attitudes* and a *Negative attitudes* score for each participant. It is important to notice that general scores between 1 and 3 represent disagreement with the statements, while scores between 3 and 5 represent agreement with them. Means closer to 3 represent more neutral attitudes towards the content of the statements. The scores can be found in chapter 4. Separate statistical analyses were also conducted comparing the different topic areas within the positive and negative statements, and the results are discussed in chapter 4.

3.6 Sociolinguistic questionnaire

As mentioned in section 3.1, each informant participated in a data collection session with the researcher, in which they were asked to perform five tasks. The first of these tasks was to fill out a background questionnaire whose main goal was to confirm that the participant was eligible to participate in the study, according to the criteria detailed in subsection 3.1.1. The questionnaire gathered sociolinguistic data about the participant, such as their age and gender, their place of birth, the number of years they have lived in the US, in case they were not born in the country, and the age in which they started learning both BP and English. Similar data was collected about their parents, since having at least one parent who is a native speaker of BP is one of the eligibility criteria to participate in the study. Other data relevant to the eligibility for the study was also collected, such as information about schooling, to make sure participants had completed their primary and secondary education in the US. Information about language use was also gathered, since another one of the conditions of participation is that the informant interacts in BP at least in some contexts with the parent or parents who are native speakers of BP. Finally, participants were also asked to evaluate their general communicative ability in Portuguese, using one of the following options (i) Not at all, (ii) Poorly, (iii) Reasonably well, (iv) Well, (v) Very well to complete the statement “I can communicate with Portuguese

speakers:” These categories are the same ones used in the questionnaire designed for the self-evaluation of their functional communication ability in Portuguese, detailed in subsection, and discussion about correlations between the overall proficiency self-assessment that they did in the sociolinguistic questionnaire and the more detailed self-evaluation they did in the self-assessment questionnaire can be found in chapter 4.

Next chapter presents the analysis of the data used to answer the research questions and test the hypotheses detailed in this chapter.

CHAPTER 4

RESULTS

This chapter details the results obtained for each one of the main variables of the study, as described in the previous chapter, after the analyses of the questionnaires and the interview were performed, as well as the correlations found between oral proficiency and each of the other variables. The chapter is divided into three main sections: In section 4.1, we look at the general results obtained for each one of the variables in question (oral proficiency, cultural practices, positive and negative attitudes). Section 4.2 examines the potential correlations between the variables, and section 4.3 presents the analysis of the results. We also consider some other factors that could potentially have an impact on our participants' oral proficiency in section 4.3.4.

4.1 General results

4.1.1 Oral proficiency

As we saw in section 3.3, the data used for the oral proficiency assessment was gathered through an oral interview with the researcher, which was posteriorly evaluated by two native speakers of Brazilian Portuguese using a functional scale developed specifically for this study. This scale, which can be found in subsection 3.3.3, foregoes detailed analyses of grammatical accuracy, vocabulary appropriateness, or quality of accent, which are measures used in some of the studies described in chapter 2. The risk of relying too much on this kind of measures is that heritage speakers who had formal instruction in their heritage language would probably be evaluated as more

proficient than the ones who did not have such formal training, even if their functional communicative abilities are similar. By using a functional scale, it is possible to include all profiles of heritage speakers, avoiding the risk of discriminating against the ones who might be able to communicate very effectively in the heritage language, despite not having any or much formal instruction in it and perhaps speaking a variety of the heritage language that does not carry social prestige.

Before the oral interview with the researcher, the informants were asked to self-evaluate their own oral proficiency levels, using a functional scale that mirrors the one used by the evaluators. This scale can be found in subsection 3.3.2. As we saw in subsection 3.3.1, some studies, such as Hakuta and D'andrea (1992) and Swender et al. (2014), point to discrepancies between self-assessed and independently-assessed levels of proficiency in heritage speakers. With the data obtained through this self-evaluation, it was possible to investigate a possible correlation between the self-assessed and the independently assessed levels of oral proficiency, which will be discussed below.

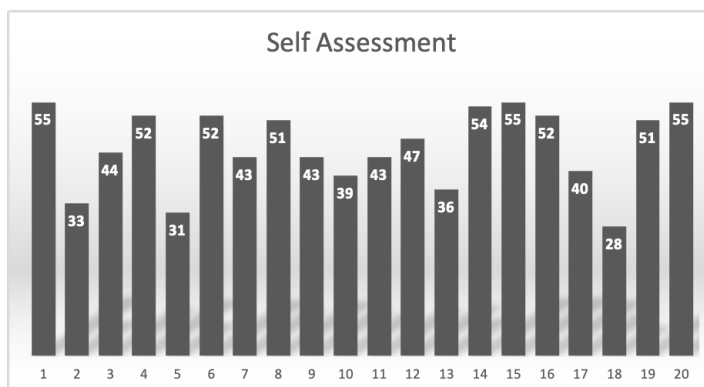


Figure 4.1. Self-assessed oral proficiency scores

The results show that for the self-assessed proficiency score, the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 55 (out of 55), and the minimum was 28, resulting in a range of 27. The mean of the results was 45.2, while the median

was 45.5, with a standard deviation of 8.54. In figure 4.1 we see the results for the self-evaluation of oral proficiency obtained per participant.

The independently-assessed proficiency scores reflect the average of the scores assigned by two independent graders. The results show that the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 53.5 (also out of 55), and the minimum was 31, resulting in a range of 22.5. The mean of the results was 46.4, while the median was 49, with a standard deviation of 6.40. In figure 4.2 we see the results obtained for each participant.

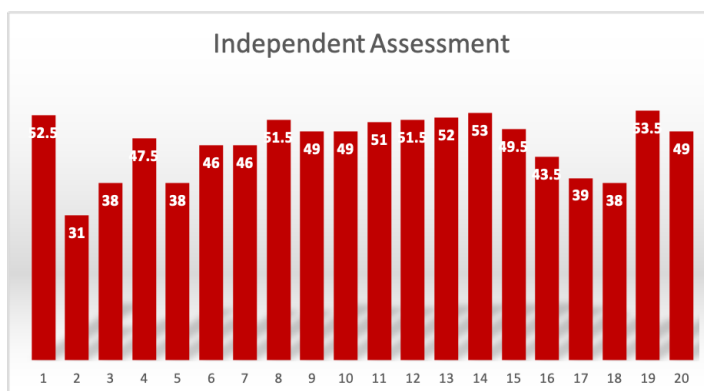


Figure 4.2. Independently assessed oral proficiency scores

Using regression analysis, I examined the strength of the possible correlation between the two proficiency scores. Figure 4.3 shows a plot graph with a regression line between the two variables. The correlation coefficient between the two variables is 0.6313, which, according to commonly used cut-off points, shows a moderate to strong correlation between them. The p value for the correlation is 0.003, which shows it is statistically significant. The analysis did not indicate any statistically significant outliers¹.

¹Outliers were established based on the value of the standard residuals calculated for each individual. There were no values higher than 3 or lower than -3.

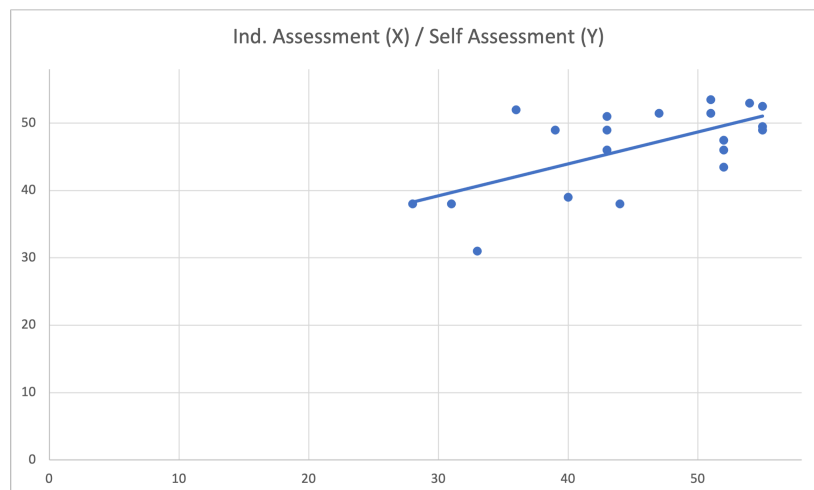


Figure 4.3. Correlation between the two oral proficiency scores

As we saw above, other studies point to discrepancies between self-assessed oral proficiency scores and independently assessed scores, but this study finds a statistically significant correlation between these two measures. This discrepancy in results might be due to the fact that in this study the scales used for both assessments are parallel, which allows for a much more direct comparison between the two, while in other studies, such as Hakuta and D'andrea (1992) and Swender et al. (2014), the instruments used to independently evaluate the informants' oral proficiency are very different from the ones used by the informants to self-evaluate their oral proficiency. Another possible explanation is, of course, differences in the group of informants. As mentioned in chapters 1 and 3, heritage speakers are a very heterogeneous group, and it is possible that the same study carried out with a different set of participants would yield different results. Since we cannot generalize these results to all groups of heritage speakers, the question of the appropriateness of using self-assessment as a reliable measure of oral proficiency for this population is still open. For this reason, in this study the *independent oral proficiency score* is used to analyze the potential correlations between oral proficiency and the other variables.

4.1.2 Cultural practices

As we saw in section 3.4, the variable *cultural practices* in this study refers to everyday practices in which heritage speakers get the opportunity to be exposed to and interact with their heritage culture and language. As we saw in chapters 2 and 3, previous studies have found correlations between oral proficiency in heritage speakers and their cultural practices, but those studies operationalize both variables in vary different ways. The most important ones when compared with this study are their reliance solely on self-assessment (Lee, 2002) and the indiscriminate combination of variables that mix heritage speakers' feelings about their language and culture and their actual practices in relation to their heritage language and culture to create a score that measures cultural practices and/or cultural identity (Lee, 2002; Oh and Au, 2005).

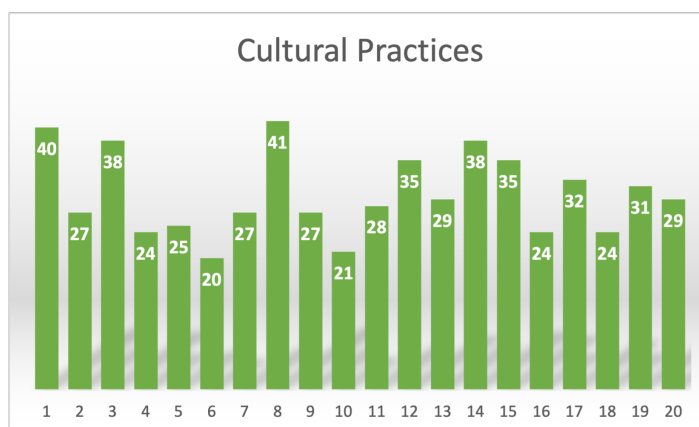


Figure 4.4. Cultural practices scores

In this study, the *cultural practices* variable is evaluated in relation to the frequency with which informants engage in activities that allow them to interact with their heritage language and culture, which could potentially expand their exposure to the heritage language and, consequently, impact their oral proficiency. The data regarding this variable was gathered by means of a questionnaire with nine statements, which can be found in section 3.4.2. The results show that the maximum number

of points obtained by a participant was 41 (out of 45), and the minimum was 20, resulting in a range of 21. The mean of the results was 29.8, while the median was 28.5, with a standard deviation of 6.28. In figure 4.4, we see the individual results obtained for each participant. The potential correlation between *cultural practices* and *oral proficiency* is analyzed in section 4.2.1.

4.1.3 Attitudes

As we saw in section 3.5.1, in this study the variable *attitudes* is actually broken down into *positive attitudes* and *negative attitudes* because of the initial results described in Cunha (2019), which shows a higher probability of a correlation between oral proficiency and negative attitudes. During the data collection process, the participants used one questionnaire (available in the appendix) that contained 9 positive and 9 negative attitude statements, but the analyses of the results was conducted separately for each kind of attitude. The results for both the *positive attitudes scores* and the *negative attitudes scores* are shown in sections 4.1.5 and 4.1.4.

As detailed in section 3.5.1, I also conducted separate analyses for three different attitude topic areas: (i) Brazilian Portuguese itself, (ii) bilingualism and biculturalism, and (iii) immigration in the US, since Cherciov (2012) showed that bilinguals can have different attitudes in relation to their own languages and towards bilingualism itself. Again, during the data collection the informants had access to only one questionnaire with questions about the three topic areas alternating randomly. These results are shown in 4.1.6.

4.1.4 Positive attitudes

Nine of the statements in the questionnaire expressed positive attitudes, so the maximum number of points a participant can get for the *positive attitudes score* is 45, and the minimum is 9. The results obtained show that the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 45, and the minimum was 32, resulting in

a range of 13. The mean of the results was 40.6, while the median was 42, with a standard deviation of 3.91. Figure 4.5 shows the individual results obtained per participant.

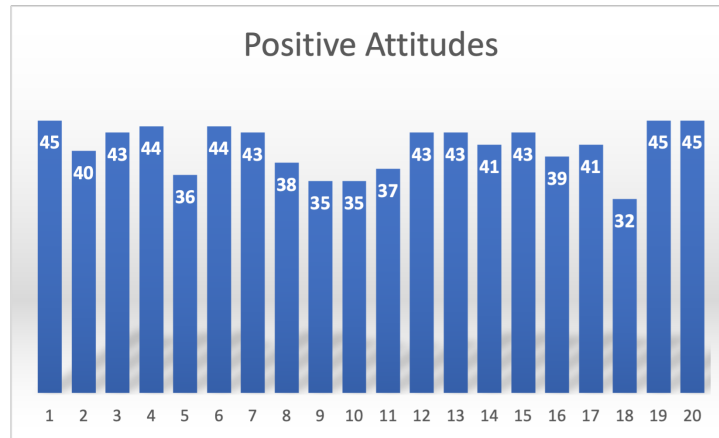


Figure 4.5. Positive Attitudes scores

4.1.5 Negative attitudes

Similarly, nine of the statements in the questionnaire expressed negative attitudes. The results obtained show that the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 26, and the minimum was 15, resulting in a range of 11. The mean of the results was 18.5, while the median was 18, with a standard deviation of 3.56. Figure 4.6 shows the individual results obtained for each participant.

When we compare the results from the positive and the negative attitude scores, it is clear that the group of informants as a whole holds much more positive than negative attitudes towards the topics listed in this study. The difference between the mean for positive attitudes (40.6) to the negative ones (18.5) is 22.1, which represents a difference of almost 50%. The close proximity of range and standard deviations for the scores on both positive and negative attitudes show us that this tendency to have more positive than negative attitudes is true across the board within the group.

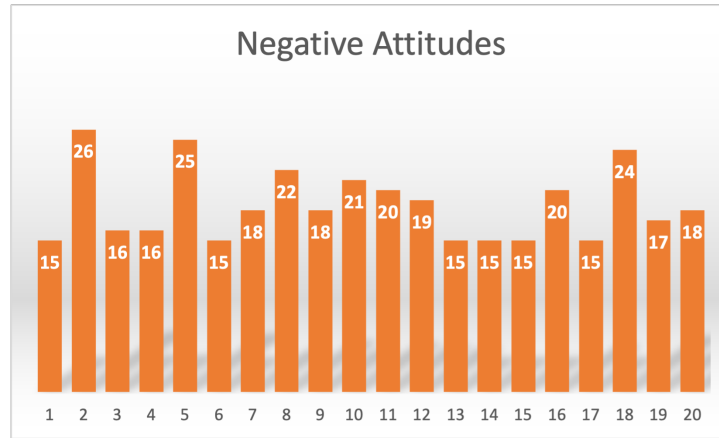


Figure 4.6. Negative Attitudes scores

The reasons for the prevalence of positive attitudes in comparison to negative attitudes can be many, and it can certainly be argued that the same study performed with a different group of informants could result in different numbers. However, the observed differences held by this group support the hypothesis that their potential correlation with the participants' oral proficiency should be evaluated separately.

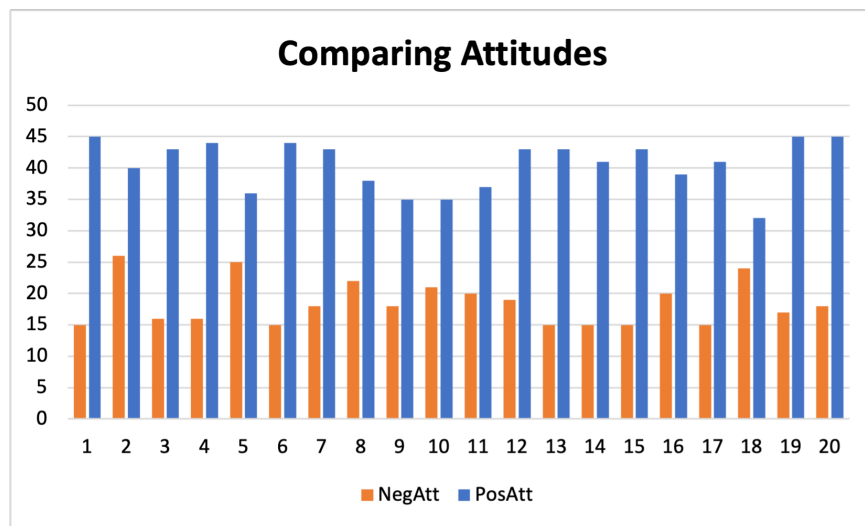


Figure 4.7. Comparing Positive and Negative Attitudes scores

Figure 4.7 shows the individual differences in positive and negative attitudes per participant. Overall, by observing individual differences, one can see that there are

several cases where a lower positive attitude score comes together with a higher negative attitude score, such as in participants 5, 10 and 18.

4.1.6 Attitudes by topic areas

As we saw above in section 4.1.3, the statements about participants' attitudes were divided into three topic areas: *the Portuguese language, bilingualism and biculturalism*, and *immigration in the US*. For each topic there were three positive and three negative statements, and based on the likert scale used, the maximum number of points were 15 and the minimum 3 per area.

Regarding positive attitudes towards the Portuguese language, the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 15, and the minimum was 11, resulting in a range of 4. The mean was 13.8, while the median was 14, with a standard deviation of 1.32. For the negative Portuguese attitudes scores, the results show that the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 9, and the minimum was 3, resulting in a range of 6. The mean was 4.95, and the median was 5, with a standard deviation of 1.88.

The second topic area is bilingualism and biculturalism. The results show that for positive attitudes, the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 15, and the minimum was 11, resulting in a range of 4. The mean of the results was 13.8, while the median was 14, with a standard deviation of 1.20. For the negative bilingualism and biculturalism attitudes score, the results show that the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 11, and the minimum was 3, resulting in a range of 8. The mean of the results was 6.45, while the median was 6, with a standard deviation of 2.16.

Finally, the last topic area is immigration in the US. The results show that for positive attitudes, the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 15, and the minimum was 8, resulting in a range of 7. The mean of the results

was 12.9, while the median was 13.5, with a standard deviation of 2.00. For the negative attitudes, the results show that the maximum number of points obtained by a participant was 11, and the minimum was 5, resulting in a range of 6. The mean of the results was 7.20, while the median was 7, with a standard deviation of 1.64. Figure 4.8 shows a comparison of the means obtained both for positive and negative attitudes by topic areas.

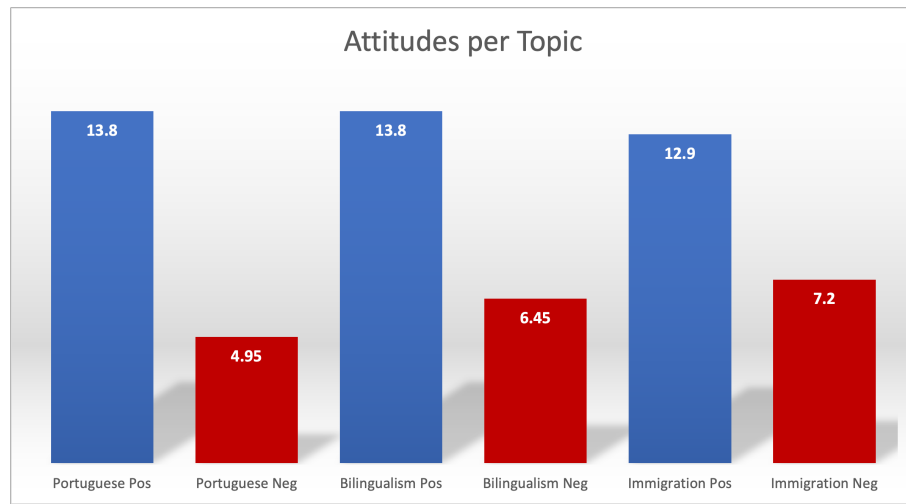


Figure 4.8. Mean of attitudes scores per topic

It is interesting to see that while the positive attitudes by topic are consistently high, the negative ones show a greater variability. The mean for negative attitudes towards BP is considerably lower than the means for the other two topic areas, with immigration being the topic with the highest mean for negative attitudes. To find out whether the differences between the means within positive and negative topics were statistically significant, I ran a Kruskal-Wallis H-test with the results for the three positive topic areas, and another one with the results for the three negative ones. For positive attitudes, the difference between the three scores by topic was not statistically significant ($p = 0.234$; $X^2 = 2.91$). However, for the negative attitudes, the difference was significant ($p = 0.002$; $X^2 = 12.9$). A post hoc analysis of the negative attitudes topics groups by pairs, carried out with a DSCF test, showed that

the difference between bilingualism/biculturalism and immigration is not statistically significant ($p = 0.339$), while the difference between Portuguese and immigration is statistically significant ($p = 0.001$). The difference between Portuguese and bilingualism/biculturalism, while not statistically significant, shows a tendency toward significance ($p = 0.060$).

These numbers suggest that while the informants do not hold strong negative attitudes towards their heritage language, they do hold significant negative attitudes towards immigration in the US. Since we do find in this study a statistically significant correlation between negative attitudes and oral proficiency (see section 4.2.3 below), we can see that, even if heritage speakers do not have negative attitudes directed specifically towards their own heritage language and culture, as is the case for the informants in this study, their negative attitudes towards the other two topic areas, especially towards immigration in the US, are enough to correlate the overall negative attitudes scores with lower oral proficiency levels.

It is also interesting to notice that the range and SDs in positive attitudes are smaller than those for negative attitudes. These results indicate a greater variability within our group in their negative attitudes, which supports the hypothesis that negative attitudes are a better source of information to scrutinize individual attitudes towards a certain topic, and potentially provide more precise evidence when correlated to other variables, such as language performance (as we will see below).

4.2 Correlations between variables

The main research questions in the study concern the potential correlations between the variables presented above. In this section I use regression analyses to examine the correlations and answer the questions presented in section 3.2.

4.2.1 Oral Proficiency and Cultural Practices

The first research question evaluates a possible correlation between the *oral proficiency* of heritage speakers and their *cultural practices*. My hypothesis was that I would find such correlation. To answer this question I plotted the results for both variables presented above, as seen in figure 4.9, and ran a regression analysis to look into the strength of the correlation between both scores.

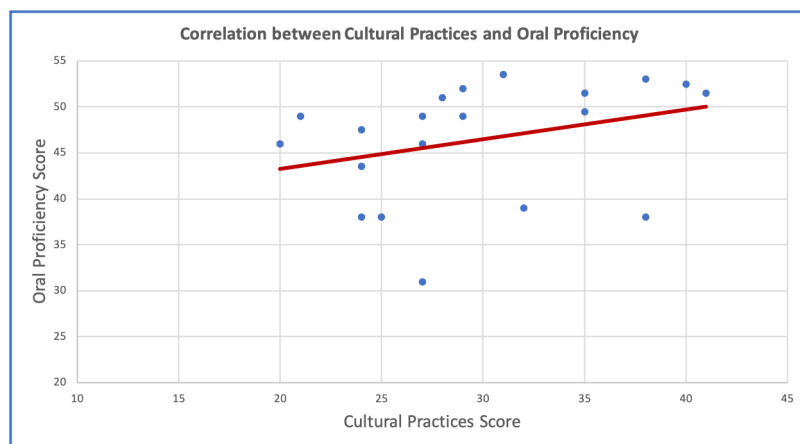


Figure 4.9. Correlation between Oral Proficiency and Cultural Practices

The results show a weak correlation coefficient ($R = 0.3168$) that is not statistically significant ($p = 0.1736$). In other words, the data does not confirm the hypothesis, as I did not find a correlation between cultural practices and oral proficiency in this group of heritage speakers of Brazilian Portuguese. These results will be further discussed in section 4.3.

4.2.2 Oral proficiency and Positive attitudes

The second research question was about a potential correlation between the heritage speakers' *oral proficiency* and their *positive attitudes* towards their heritage language, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US. My hypothesis was that a higher positive attitudes score would translate into higher oral proficiency scores. To answer this question, I did a similar procedure to the one presented for the

first question. I plotted the results for both variables, as seen in figure 4.10, and ran a regression analysis to look into the strength of the correlation between both scores.

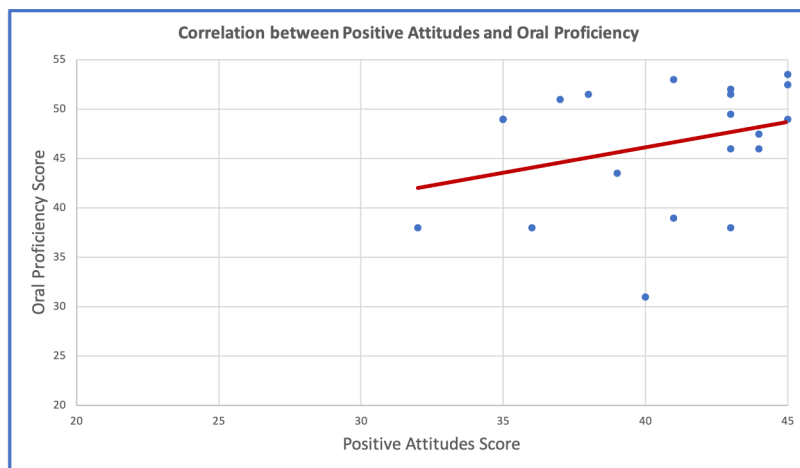


Figure 4.10. Correlation between Oral Proficiency and Positive Attitudes

These results also show a weak correlation coefficient ($R = 0.3138$) that is not statistically significant ($p = 0.178$). Once again the data does not support the hypothesis, since there was not a statistically significant correlation between heritage speakers' oral proficiency and their positive attitudes. Further discussion of these results will be presented in section 4.3.2.

4.2.3 Oral proficiency and Negative attitudes

The last research question was related to the possible correlation between heritage speakers' *oral proficiency* and their *negative attitudes* towards their heritage language, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US. My hypothesis was that a higher *negative attitudes* score would correlate to a lower *oral proficiency* score, while a lower *negative attitudes* score would correlate to a higher *oral proficiency* score in heritage speakers. In other words, the variables would be negatively correlated. Similarly to the questions above, I plotted the results for both variables, as seen in

figure 4.11, and ran a regression analysis to look into the strength of the correlation between both scores.

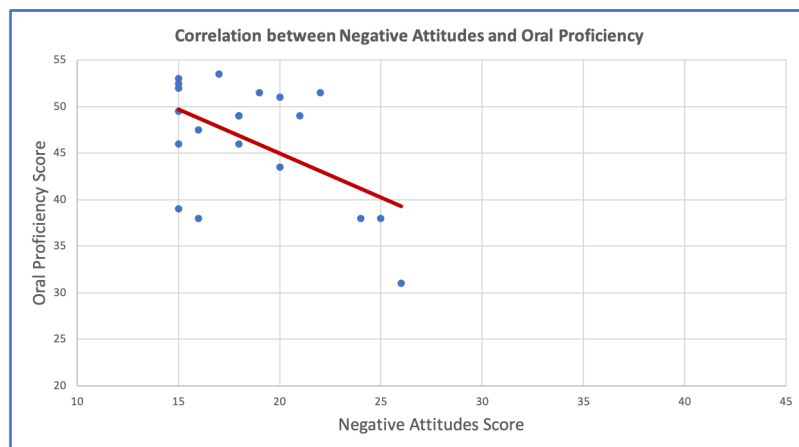


Figure 4.11. Correlation between Oral Proficiency and Negative Attitudes

Differently from the other two independent variables, the results showed a moderate correlation coefficient ($R = 0.53$) that is statistically significant ($p = 0.016$). Those numbers confirm the third hypothesis, since they show that the negative attitudes score is as expected negatively correlated to the participants' oral proficiency.

4.3 Analysis

This section presents an analysis of the results from the previous section in light of the aims of this study and the previous literature in the field. The first three subsections (4.3.1, 4.3.2, and 4.3.3) discuss some consequences of the correlations between oral proficiency and the primary independent variables used in the research questions, and in 4.3.4 I explore other descriptive variables found in the background questionnaire and their possible correlations with the the oral proficiency scores.

4.3.1 Oral proficiency and cultural practices

Considering the lack of correlation between oral proficiency and cultural practices found in this study, it seems important to consider the premise that exposure to the

heritage culture can contribute to higher proficiency levels in heritage speakers. This premise may very well be true, but this relationship is probably not so simple and/or direct. In other words, a higher degree of exposure to the heritage culture will not necessarily result in higher levels of proficiency in the heritage language. It might be the case, for instance, that a somewhat passive exposure to culture, which could happen when a person eats the typical food of the heritage country or listens to music from the heritage country, for example, is not enough to impact oral proficiency in the heritage language. These were exactly the kinds of activities that were measured with our cultural practices questionnaire (available in the appendix) and in questions 11 and 12 of the oral interview, which asked informants to talk about their relationship with Brazilian culture and BP and about their level of contact with other Brazilians or Brazilian-Americans in their place of origin in the US. However, other kinds of engagement that can lead to more significant language exposure are perhaps more impactful, such as trips to the heritage country.

To further look into this question, I included in our background questionnaire questions about trips to Brazil, specifically short vacation trips with their families (less than one month), longer family trips (more than one month), and solo trips without their families. The purpose of asking about solo trips in particular was to find out whether the informant had the opportunity to be in Brazil without any English speakers who could help them in any situation in which their knowledge of Portuguese might have proved insufficient. I then cross listed those answers with participants proficiency scores. I analyzed each kind of trip mentioned above, creating for each one two groups of informants, one that had taken at least one such trip and the other that did not take any trip of the kind. The results are summarized in table 4.1.

Type of trip	Response	# Participants	Mean Oral Score	Significance
Vacation	Yes	12	45.8	No $p=0.73$
	No	8	47.3	
Long trip	Yes	8	46.6	No $p=0.56$
	No	12	46.3	
Solo trip	Yes	6	47.8	No $p=0.77$
	No	14	45.8	

Table 4.1. Group mean of oral scores per type of trip to Brazil

For the first kind of trip, family vacations lasting less than one month, the *Yes* group was comprised of 12 informants, while the *No* group had eight informants. For the second kind of trip, family vacations lasting longer than one month, eight informants responded *Yes*, while 12 said *No*. For the third kind of trip, solo travels, the *Yes* group had six informants, while the *No* group had 14. I then calculated the mean of the oral proficiency score of each group, and performed Mann-Whitney tests to determine if the difference between the *Yes* and *No* groups for each kind of trip was statistically significant. For the first kind of trip, the *Yes* group had an oral proficiency score mean of 45.8, while the *No* group had an oral proficiency score mean of 47.3. While the result itself is surprising because the group that had never traveled to Brazil outperformed the one that did visit the country, the difference is not statistically significant ($p = 0.73$, $U = 43$, *Critical* $U = 22$). For the second kind of trip, the *Yes* group had an oral proficiency score mean of 46.6, while the *No* group had an oral proficiency score mean of 46.3. The means are very similar, and the Mann-Whitney test showed again that the difference is not statistically significant ($p = 0.56$, $U = 40$, *Critical* $U = 22$). For the third kind of trip, the *Yes* group had an oral proficiency score mean of 47.8, while the *No* group had an oral proficiency score mean of 45.8. The difference in means for this kind of trip is the highest, but it is still not statistically significant ($p = 0.77$, $U = 38$, *Critical* $U = 17$).

These results are very interesting if we consider the well-established argument in the field that proficiency scores are directly correlated with the quality and amount of input received by language learners (e.g., Benmamoun et al., 2010). Since trips to the country where the heritage language is the dominant one can provide more opportunities for richer input, something must be happening in the experiences of the participants that have never traveled abroad to compensate for the lack of exposure provided by these trips. Perhaps the most appropriate way to answer this question would be to design an ethnographic study, where everyday behavior towards language use can be observed. Since the methodology used in this study was based on questionnaires and a single interview as the elicitation mechanisms, it only allows us to speculate about possible reasons for the observed behavior, which would need to be verified by future studies. Interestingly, this phenomenon seems to indicate one of the limitations of studies that attempt to observe *cultural practices* and operationalize this concept without long-term and in-depth observations of participants.

When we compare the results found in this study with the ones in Oh and Au (2005) presented in chapter 2, it is easy to see how the operationalization of the variables can play a significant role in data collection, codification, and analysis. Oh and Au (2005) find a correlation between the oral proficiency levels of Spanish heritage speakers, measured in terms of nativeness of accent, and a cultural participation score, measured in terms of agreement with sentences such as “I like meeting and getting to know people of Latino background.” As we can see, both variables are operationalized very differently from this study, which evaluates oral proficiency in terms of ability to perform specific communicative functions, and measures cultural practices in terms of frequency of actions. In the same study by Oh and Au (2005), the authors do not find any statistically significant correlations between their participants cultural participation scores and the two other proficiency measures they used, which are a grammaticality judgment test and a grammar mastery test. While

there is no one correct way of measuring variables such as oral proficiency or cultural practices, this difference in results between the two studies shows once again how important methodological choices are in any study, since they have the potential of determining the results obtained. Even more important than to argue which methodological choice is the most appropriate, which is beyond the scope of this project, it is important to recognize the challenges in the operationalization of certain concepts into variables, and encourage future debate and research in the field in order to advance our understanding of human behavior that could influence the dissemination and acquisition in heritage language scenarios.

4.3.2 Oral proficiency and positive attitudes

As we saw in chapter 2, previous studies, such as Lambert and Taylor (1996), Beckstead and Toribio (2003), Mejías et al. (2003), MacGregor-Mendoza (2015), and Gubitosi and de Oliveira (2020), find correlations between positive language attitudes and language maintenance and use in heritage speakers. However, we need to remember that language maintenance/use and language proficiency are two very different variables, and that language use does not translate necessarily into higher levels of proficiency in the heritage language. There is not a lot of investigation conducted about possible correlations between positive attitudes and oral proficiency, and the studies that do exist, such as Lee (2002), operationalize these variables differently from the way I do it here. For the oral proficiency score, Lee (2002) uses self-assessment as the only measure, and as we saw in section 4.1.1, the question of the appropriateness of self-assessment as a measure of oral proficiency is still open. Regarding attitudes, Lee (2002) uses a variable called degree of biculturalism, of which attitudes is just one of the components. Some of the sentences used in her biculturalism index questionnaire are what in this study we call attitudes statements, such as “I’m proud to be Korean”, while others are what we call in this study cultural participation statements, such as

“My family and I celebrate most Korean traditions.’ It is difficult, then, to compare this study findings with any others, since there is not a lot of previous work that operationalizes these variables in the same way I do here.

The fact that I did not find a statistically significant correlation between oral proficiency and positive attitudes in this study can be due to several factors. The first explanation could be that positive attitudes do not have a significant impact on language proficiency levels for our informants because, as we saw above, as a group they uniformly have very high scores for positive attitudes, especially towards Brazilian Portuguese itself and towards bilingualism and biculturalism.

Besides the high positive attitudes scores found through the quantitative analysis of the degree of agreement expressed by the informants in relation to the statements in the attitudes questionnaire, we will see in chapter 5 that a qualitative analysis of some of the informants’ answers to specific questions of the oral interview also show that our participants do not see their heritage language or their status as bilinguals as problematic.

It is important to remember that all participants in this study were college students, and were this study to be repeated with a group of BP heritage speakers with different educational background or with heritage speakers of other languages, the results could be different. For our informants, however, the positive attitudes scores regarding all three topic areas are very high, which lead to a diminished impact of this variable on their oral proficiency scores.

4.3.3 Oral proficiency and negative attitudes

Some studies detailed in chapter 2 (e.g., Tse, 2000; Lee, 2002; Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe, 2009) find that negative attitudes can have an influence on language maintenance and use, since they impact heritage speakers’ motivation and willingness to learn their heritage language and/or to invest in keeping their language abilities. To

my knowledge, prior to this study, there were no other studies that looked specifically for a correlation between negative attitudes and oral proficiency in heritage speakers, so I do not have any previous results that could be compared to the ones found in this study. The results in section 4.2.3 show that negative attitudes impacted oral proficiency within this group of participants.

Miller (2017) reminds us that young heritage speakers' attitudes do not always match the attitudes of the adults in their lives. In most cases heritage speakers' families, and specifically their parents, have very positive attitudes towards their minority language and culture, as we can see in Lambert and Taylor (1996), Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe (2009), and MacGregor-Mendoza (2015). However, that does not mean that these positive attitudes will automatically be transferred to their children, or that their families will be able to completely shield heritage speakers from developing negative attitudes towards their heritage language and culture. Many times, heritage speakers may develop negative attitudes towards their heritage language and cultures based on their own perceptions of the majority society attitudes towards them, as we can see in Tse (2000). These negative attitudes will vary from heritage group to heritage group, since the majority society's perception of each immigrant group in the US is different. As we saw in chapter 1, in the US specifically, Brazilians are somewhat under the radar, so maybe we do not see in our informants very pronounced negative attitudes, as we see in the heritage speakers of Asian origin that form Tse's participant group. However, our study shows that these negative attitudes are nevertheless already having an impact on our participants' oral proficiency.

The fact that most of the negative attitudes we see in our participants are related to the topic area of immigration in the US, as we can see in figure 4.8 and in the participants' comments mentioned in chapter 5, is another interesting finding of this study. At the time of data collection, the political environment in the US was very hostile to immigrants, and negative messages about immigrants were being incessantly

heard on the media and social networks. It is not a huge stretch to conclude that these messages had an impact on our informants, and contributed to the negative attitudes towards immigration expressed by some of them.

If one of our goals as researchers working with heritage speakers in the US is to promote the maintenance of heritage languages and help heritage speakers develop and maintain proficiency in their heritage languages, our findings show that it is at least as important to combat negative attitudes towards immigrants and towards minority languages and cultures than it is to promote positive attitudes about them, if not more vital. Moreover, immigrant families cannot be expected to carry this task by themselves. Other institutions, such as schools and universities, also have an important role in combating these negative messages.

4.3.4 Other factors potentially impacting oral proficiency

In the sociolinguistic questionnaire I gathered some data about our participants's personal characteristics that, while not directly related to this study's main research questions, may present potential correlations with their oral proficiency scores.

One such characteristic is having only one parent who is a native speaker of BP versus having two native speaker parents. If both parents are native speakers of BP, the amount of input that the heritage speaker receives in the heritage language could potentially be higher than in the cases where only one parent is a native speaker. As indicated by previous research (e.g., Benmamoun et al., 2010), the amount of input can play a significantly role in heritage language acquisition. In this study, 15 out of our 20 informants have both parents who are native speakers of BP, and only five have only native speaker parent. The mean oral proficiency score for the 2-parent group is 48.9 (out of 55), while the 1-parent group is 39. Comparing the results using a Mann-Whitney test, I found that the difference between groups is statistically significant ($p = 0.011$, $U = 8$, *Critical* $U = 14$). These results, which are shown in table 4.2,

align with previous studies that show the importance input has on the development of oral proficiency in heritage speakers. Even if heritage speakers and their families cannot change the fact that only one or two of the parents are native speakers of their minority language, they can still search for ways of increasing the amount of input in the language to which the heritage speaker is exposed. The majority society could help immigrants in this task by offering a greater number of good quality foreign language courses as part of standard public school curricula, for instance.

Another characteristic that could potentially be correlated with heritage speakers' oral proficiency scores is the socioeconomic and educational status of the informants' families. Previous studies, such as Lambert and Taylor (1996) and MacGregor-Mendoza (2015), show that the socioeconomic and educational status of the parents do have an impact on heritage speakers and their families' language use and choice. It is reasonable to hypothesize, then, that these factors might be correlated to the heritage speakers' oral proficiency scores in this study. While I did not have access to any information about our participants' family income levels, in the background information questionnaire I asked participants to provide information about their parents educational attainment. Their answers show that a little over half of our group (11 participants) have at least one parent with a college degree or higher, while the other nine participants do not have any parent with a college degree. I separated participants in two groups: (1) at least one parent with college degree, and (2) parents without college degree, and calculated the mean of the oral proficiency score for each group. Surprisingly, group 1 has a lower mean (44.77 / 55) than group 2 (48.44 / 55). This result, however, is not statistically significant ($p = 0.197$, $U = 32$, *Critical U* = 23).

One possible explanation as to why in our study parental educational attainment does not have a statistically significant impact on our participants' independent oral proficiency scores is that our participants are themselves college students. At this age

their own educational attainment is most probably a more important factor in their heritage language use and proficiency levels than their parents' educational levels. As for the surprising results for the oral proficiency scores in the two groups, we can speculate that parents with a lower educational attainment speak less English and more Portuguese with their children, which could have increased that amount of input in Portuguese this group was exposed to. This exposure could have had a positive impact on their oral proficiency scores, although not a statistically significant one. We must also remember that Lambert and Taylor (1996) and MacGregor-Mendoza (2015) investigate language choice and use in immigrant parents and their school-age children. For these young children, their parents educational attainment could be more significant for their own language choice and use. We must also remember that these studies do not measure language proficiency, but language use and choice², which makes it hard to compare their findings with the ones in this study. We can see a summary of the data in table 4.2.

Variable	Response	# Participants	Mean Oral Score	Significance
Parent with college degree	Yes	11	44.8	No p=0.21
	No	9	48.4	
# of parents who speak BP	1 parent	5	39	Yes p=0.0008
	2 parents	15	48.9	

Table 4.2. Other variables and oral proficiency

I also looked at the potential correlation between informants' oral proficiency scores and their pre-college studies in Portuguese. As mentioned in section 3.1.1, among the 20 participants, only two of them reported studying Portuguese at school in

²It is true that Lambert and Taylor (1996) does measure proficiency, but only in an indirect way, by asking their informants, who are Spanish-speaking immigrant mothers, to evaluate their children's proficiency in both English and Spanish based on their own impressions and on school report cards and teachers' comments.

the US before starting college. Participant 2 attended a bilingual English/Portuguese program in elementary school between kindergarten and third grade, plus four years of Portuguese as a foreign language in high school, while participant 16 took seven years of Portuguese as a foreign language in middle and high school. As we can see in figure 4.2, though, participant 2 has the lowest independent oral proficiency score of all participants (31 out of 55), while participant 16 has an independent oral proficiency score of 43.5, which is below the mean and the median for all participants (46.4 and 49, respectively.)

We cannot generalize any conclusions about the lack of impact of formal schooling in Portuguese based on two informants only, but these numbers show us that, at least in the case of these two people, participation in Portuguese language classes in childhood did not translate into higher oral proficiency levels.

We see a similar lack of formal instruction impact for the informants in Tse (2000), Lee (2002), and Zhang and Slaughter-Defoe (2009). In Lee (2002), the group of informants who attended community language schools reported lower self-assessed proficiency levels in Korean than the group who did not attend classes in these community schools. Moreover, in all three studies, informants who participated in community-organized classes for their heritage languages as children do not perceive these classes as important, since they are offered outside the formal schooling system. In their interpretation, the message conveyed by this is that their heritage languages are not important enough to be a school subject. The results for our participants may point to something worse: even when a heritage language is offered as a foreign language in a school system, it may not receive the resources that would make these courses an important tool to support heritage speakers in achieving high proficiency levels in their heritage language.

I also examined a potential correlation between informants' oral proficiency scores and their participation or not in at least one Portuguese course in college. As men-

tioned in chapter 3, surprisingly the participants who had not taken any courses in Portuguese in college by the time of data collection (4, 6, 7, 10, 11, and 12) actually have, as a group, a higher oral proficiency score mean (48.5) than the ones who had taken at least one course in college (45.5). However, a Mann Whitney test showed that the correlation between oral proficiency scores and having taken at least one Portuguese course in college is not statistically significant (p value = 0.94, U value = 40, *Critical U* = 17). There could be several explanations for these results. For instance, there might be differences in the amount and quality of input in Portuguese received by the participants during childhood that impacted their oral proficiency level, or the amount of exposure and engagement with Portuguese provided by one college class is insufficient to promote a significant improvement in their oral proficiency levels. At any rate, these results concerning the lack of impact of formal education on the informants' oral proficiency scores show us the importance of advocating for resources to conduct research about heritage language learning and about teaching methods that could support these learners in the task of developing high levels of proficiency in their heritage languages, and how vital it is to support efforts to supply schools and universities with the necessary resources to offer high quality language courses to heritage speaker populations and to any student interested in studying foreign languages.

CHAPTER 5

QUALITATIVE ANALYSIS

In chapter 4, we saw the results obtained for each of the main variables in this study, as well as the correlations found between informants' independently assessed oral proficiency scores and each one of these variables. In this chapter we will see global analyses of the data obtained that will provide further insight into the complex interactions between the several characteristics of our group of informants and their oral proficiency levels in BP. The chapter brings many individual testimonies that were collected during an oral interview about the topics from the questionnaires. These testimonies present a more nuanced view of how participants feel and how their responses in the questionnaire can be interpreted.

5.1 Positive attitudes

One of the surprising results of this study was the lack of a correlation between positive attitudes and oral proficiency in our group of informants. As mentioned before, previous studies found a positive correlation between positive attitudes and language maintenance and use in HS (Lee 2002, Gubitosi and de Oliveira, 2020). It was reasonable, then, to hypothesize that positive attitudes could also have a positive impact on language proficiency levels in HS. That was not the case for our group of informants, however, and as mentioned in chapter 4, one of the reasons for that is the fact that, as a group, these informants have very high scores for positive attitudes, especially towards BP and towards bilingualism and biculturalism. Table

5.1 shows participants' positive attitudes scores, together with their self-assessed and independently assessed oral proficiency scores.

Participant	Pos Att Score	Ind Prof Score	Self Prof Score
1	45	52.5	55
2	40	31	33
3	43	38	44
4	44	47.5	52
5	36	38	31
6	44	46	52
7	43	46	43
8	38	51.5	51
9	35	49	43
10	35	49	39
11	37	51	43
12	43	51.5	47
13	43	52	36
14	41	53	54
15	43	49.5	55
16	39	43.5	52
17	41	39	40
18	32	38	28
19	45	53.5	51
20	45	49	55

Table 5.1. Positive attitudes and Proficiency scores

As we can see, 13 out of the 20 informants have positive attitudes scores higher than 40.6, which was the mean of the results, with the maximum possible score being 45. Out of the 7 who have scores below 40.6, only one, participant 18, has a positive attitudes score lower than 35. Interestingly enough, despite the fact that I did not find for the group as a whole a statistically significant correlation between independently assessed oral proficiency and positive attitudes, participant 18, who has the lowest positive attitudes score, has one of the lowest independently assessed oral proficiency scores in the group (38 of 55). The same interesting phenomenon occurs with participant 5, who has a positive attitudes score of 36 out of 45 and an independent oral proficiency score of 38 out of 55. It is also interesting that both

participants 5 and 18 have the lowest self-assessed proficiency scores of all (31 and 28 out of 55, respectively).

On the other hand, participant 2, who has the lowest independently assessed oral proficiency score and the third lowest self-assessed oral proficiency score in the group (31 and 33 out of 55, respectively), has a relatively high positive attitudes score (40 out of 45).

Those numbers show us that the relationship between positive attitudes and oral proficiency is a very complex one, and analyses using multiple instruments and approaches are necessary to explain it. The oral interview data can help shed more light into these complex relationships.

The oral interview data confirms that the participants as a group hold overwhelmingly positive attitudes, especially towards BP and towards bilingualism and biculturalism. Question number 11 in the oral interview asked them to comment on their relationship with Brazil, Brazilian culture, and Portuguese. All informants characterized this relationship as a positive one, and commented on being happy to be Brazilians and be able to speak Portuguese. Some reported on making efforts to keep their knowledge of BP or improve it. Participant 3, for instance, said “...I try my best to connect to Brazil. For instance, when there’s a Netflix show in Portuguese, I watch it, because I want to learn the slang, I want to improve my Portuguese, I want to improve my vocabulary, I’m trying to improve my conjugations...I do this a lot to try to connect with Brazil and also with Portuguese.” Talking about applying to college, he added “It was very easy for me to write my college essays, because knowing Portuguese gave me a kind of quality that other people don’t have.”¹

Despite this overwhelmingly positive attitude, participant 3 received a 38 out of 55 as an independently assessed proficiency score, which shows us that positive attitudes

¹All the oral interview quotes in this chapter were translated by the researcher.

do not necessarily translate into higher proficiency levels. Interestingly, participant 3's self-assessed score was much higher (44 out of 55), and we can speculate that his high level of motivation to expand his knowledge of BP might contribute to this high evaluation of his abilities in the language.

Participant 5 is another interesting case. In the oral interview he said: "I listen to Brazilian music every day, and I try to read a Brazilian paper two or three times per week. I don't know much (about Brazil), but I try to find out what's happening over there." He also mentioned: "I love Brazilian food, the other day I made *pão de queijo* in my house, and my roommate loved it. He's American." Despite all this motivation and positive attitudes expressed in the interview, this participant has a low independently assessed oral proficiency score (38 out of 55) and an even lower self-assessed oral proficiency score (31 out of 55), which shows us once again that positive attitudes do not necessarily translate into higher levels of oral proficiency in the heritage language. Even more interesting, this participant's positive attitudes score, measured by the questionnaire, is 36 out of 45, the fourth lowest score of the entire group. This mismatch between the enthusiasm about Brazil expressed in the interview and the low positive attitudes score measured by the questionnaire shows us once more the methodological complexities involved in measuring attitudes, and the need for the use of multiple data collection instruments in studies concerning them.

To learn more about the informants' attitudes towards being bilingual, I included a question in the oral interview that asked how they felt speaking BP in public with their families and what they believed the people around them thought when they heard the family speaking Portuguese. They rarely reported negative feelings; on the contrary, some of them reported feeling proud to be able to show they know how to speak another language, and also talked about the advantages of being able to communicate in another language, such as being able to make comments that the people around cannot understand. As for the people overhearing them, the most cited feeling was

“curiosity”, which is a neutral to positive feeling. Participant 3 commented: “In my city some people thought it was cool that I spoke Portuguese.” He also said “I think it’s cool, because I can say anything and nobody will understand...when my dad scolded me, I always asked him to speak in Portuguese, because nobody could understand when he spoke in Portuguese.” He ended his answer saying: “I’m very proud to speak Portuguese, to have this kind of knowledge of Portuguese.” Again, we can see that this participant has very positive attitudes towards being bilingual, but these attitudes do not translate into very high oral proficiency scores. Participant 5 said: “If it’s important that other people are not able to understand what I say, if it’s something private, I speak in Portuguese (when I’m in public with my family).” Again, we see that participant 5 expresses more positive attitudes in his answers in the interview than in his answers in the questionnaire.

The topic for which the participants had the lowest positive attitudes scores was immigration in the US. As we can see in figure 5.1, despite the fact that the means for all attitudes topics are high, the means of positive attitudes for BP and for bilingualism and biculturalism are higher than the ones for immigration in the US.

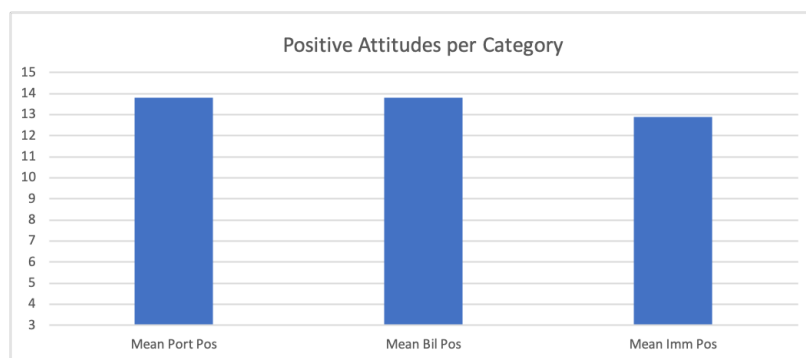


Figure 5.1. Positive attitudes per category

Data from the oral interview show that some of the informants either avoided talking about this topic, expressed a lack of opinion about it, or a difficulty in forming an opinion about it. Participant 11, who has the third lowest positive attitudes in rela-

tion to immigration in the entire group (10 out of 15), expresses hesitation and doubt about immigration: “I don’t have a completely formed opinion (about immigration), because I think I grew up with two different perspectives. My parents are politically more conservative and they came to the US by conventional, legal methods, so they have always had a more negative perception of illegal immigrants. So, it’s hard (to have an opinion about immigration) because there’s a humanitarian aspect, there are situations on the border that never in a thousand years should have happened, from a moral point of view. However, there are laws. I don’t know if I agree with methods that use trespassing...I know that sometimes it’s necessary, and I know people who escaped from situations because they needed to, but this past summer, for instance, we hosted a mother and her son at home for a month (...) the more I learned about the way in which they entered the country, the more my opinion became more radicalized. Because they told me stories about other people who tried to enter using the same method they did that shocked me. People who didn’t succeed, people who had to return to countries that really were in crisis, people who were trying to escape critical situations. Meanwhile they, who were coming from a financial situation in Brazil that wasn’t great, but was stable, managed to get here. So, I don’t know how I feel, it’s a very difficult topic. From a humanitarian point of view I disagree with the negative reaction many people have towards immigrants. After all, we’re all human beings, people have their reasons to do what they do, but I don’t know if I agree with these alternative methods for entering the country. I don’t know, I believe in laws.” Participant 5 avoided even more expressing any opinions about the topic: “To be honest I don’t have strong opinions about politics, because my opinion is that I can’t do anything, so I can’t even get mad at the president or anyone else. Because by myself there’s nothing I can do. Whatever happens, I can’t make a difference.”

Regarding the immigration topic, we can also see that some informants who have low positive attitudes scores as measured by the questionnaire expressed more positive

attitudes during the interview. This could be due to the environment in which these informants are immersed, as college students in a liberal higher education institution located in a very progressive area, which would prevent them from expressing in front of an interviewer opinions about immigration that could sound more conservative. In a questionnaire, however, these pressures are not as present, and they could have felt more at ease to select answers that are not very positive in relation to immigration. Participant 10, who has the lowest score of the entire group for positive attitudes towards immigration, did express positive attitudes towards immigration in the oral interview: “I think it’s sad, because there are many false things that people say, and because they have so much power, people can hear them and believe what they say, even if it’s not true. There is data that show that immigrant communities have low rates of crime, and also because I know many immigrants I know the kind of people they are. They are families and community members who don’t want to do anything wrong, most of them, so it’s sad that people don’t accept them.”

Despite this hesitation from the part of some informants and dubiousness from the part of others, there are participants who expressed unequivocal support for immigrants and immigration in the US. Participant 1, who has the third highest independent oral proficiency score in the entire group, said “This country was built by immigrants. (...) without immigrants this country doesn’t work. It’s a shame that this country mistreats immigrants.” Participant 13, who has the fourth highest oral proficiency score (52 out of 53), commented “When a person risks their life to come here, it’s because things at home are really not ok. They’re coming here because they really need to (...) I don’t know anybody who came here just because they were tired of living home. Everyone comes here because they need something that their country cannot give them.”

Table 5.2 below shows each participant’s positive attitudes scores by topic, together with their independently assessed oral proficiency score. When we look at the

table in conjunction with the data from the oral interview, we see that most informants are consistent in the attitudes they expressed in both the questionnaire and the interview, and cases like participant 10's are more the exception than the rule. At any rate, these few cases of mismatch show us that there are subtleties in their attitudes that are better captured when multiple data collection instruments are used.

Participant	Score BP	Score Bil/Bic	Score Imm	Pos Att Score	Ind Prof Score
1	15	15	15	45	52.5
2	13	14	13	40	31
3	15	14	14	43	38
4	14	15	15	44	47.5
5	12	11	13	36	38
6	15	15	14	44	46
7	15	14	14	43	46
8	13	13	12	38	51.5
9	11	12	12	35	49
10	14	13	8	35	49
11	13	14	10	37	51
12	14	15	14	43	51.5
13	15	14	14	43	52
14	14	14	12	41	53
15	14	15	14	43	49.5
16	13	13	12	39	43.5
17	15	13	13	41	39
18	11	12	9	32	38
19	15	15	15	45	53.5
20	15	14	15	45	49

Table 5.2. Positive attitudes per category and oral proficiency

5.2 Negative attitudes

As mentioned in chapter 4, I did find a statistically significant correlation between the informants' negative attitudes scores and their independently assessed oral proficiency scores. The lower the negative attitudes score, the higher the oral proficiency score. It was also clear that the topic about which informants hold the highest negative attitudes is immigration in the US, and the one about which they hold the lowest negative attitudes is Brazilian Portuguese, with bilingualism and biculturalism in the middle. Just as with the positive attitudes scores, the maximum number of points

a participant could obtain was 45, and the minimum was 9, and the mean of results was 18.5. 12 out of the 20 participants had negative attitudes scores lower than 18.5, while the other 8 had scores higher than 20. 26 was the highest negative attitudes score, while 15 was the lowest. Table 5.3 shows participants' negative attitudes scores, together with their self-assessed and independently assessed oral proficiency scores.

Participant	Neg Att Score	Ind Prof Score	Self Prof Score
1	15	52.5	55
2	26	31	33
3	16	38	44
4	16	47.5	52
5	25	38	31
6	15	46	52
7	18	46	43
8	22	51.5	51
9	18	49	43
10	21	49	39
11	20	51	43
12	19	51.5	47
13	15	52	36
14	15	53	54
15	15	49.5	55
16	20	43.5	52
17	15	39	40
18	24	38	28
19	17	53.5	51
20	18	49	55

Table 5.3. Negative attitudes and Proficiency scores

As we can see, informant 2 has the highest negative attitudes score, and she also has the lowest independently assessed oral proficiency score of all informants (31 out of 55). Her self-assessed oral proficiency score, although not the lowest, is the third lowest one (33 out of 35). Participants 3, 5, and 18 have the second lowest independently assessed oral proficiency scores (38 out of 55), and participants 5 and 18 also have high negative attitudes scores, 25 out of 45 and 24 out of 45, respectively, giving them the second and third highest scores in terms of negative attitudes. Out

of the ones with the lowest independently assessed oral proficiency scores, participant 3 is the only one whose negative attitudes score is low, 16 out of 45.

In terms of which topics drew more negative attitudes from the informants, we can see in picture 5.2 that the average score for immigration was the highest one.

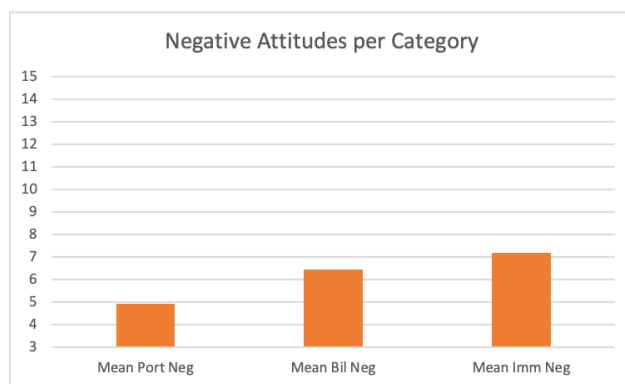


Figure 5.2. Negative attitudes per category

Data from the oral interview confirm that immigration was indeed the topic that drew the most negative responses from the informants. Question 14 asked about their opinion on the status of immigrants in the US, and as we saw above in section 5.1, some informants showed hesitation in forming an opinion about the topic, but others expressed clear negative attitudes about immigration in the US, at least about what they call illegal immigration, or about “bad” people entering the country. Participant 7, who is the middle group in terms of the independently assessed oral proficiency score (46 out of 55), commented: “I may have my opinion (about immigration), but I don’t know how to solve the problem. I know the government needs to be able to distinguish good from bad people.” Participant 18 said: “I don’t know much about immigration, I know that I support legal immigration, but I don’t support illegal immigration.”

As we can see in figure 5.2, participant 7 does not have a very high overall negative attitudes score (18 out of 45), but as table 5.4 shows, her negative attitudes towards immigration are significantly higher than her negative attitudes about BP

and higher than her negative attitudes about bilingualism and biculturalism (3, 7, and 8, respectively). Participant 18 has the second highest negative attitudes score in the entire group (24 out of 45), and he has high negative attitudes about all 3 topic areas, including BP. He actually has the highest negative attitudes score about BP in the entire group, together with participant 5.

Participant	Score BP	Score Bil/Bic	Score Imm	Neg Att Score	Ind Prof Score
1	3	5	7	15	52.5
2	6	11	9	26	31
3	4	5	7	16	38
4	5	4	7	16	47.5
5	8	7	10	25	38
6	4	5	6	15	46
7	3	7	8	18	46
8	6	6	10	22	51.5
9	5	6	7	18	49
10	5	6	7	21	49
11	3	10	7	20	51
12	4	9	6	19	51.5
13	9	4	6	15	52
14	3	6	6	15	53
15	7	3	5	15	49.5
16	5	8	7	20	43.5
17	5	4	6	15	39
18	8	6	11	24	38
19	3	9	5	17	53.5
20	3	8	7	18	49

Table 5.4. Negative attitudes per category and oral proficiency

When we analyze the overall data about negative attitudes, we can see that the informants who have the highest scores, which are 2, 5, 8, and 18, also have the lowest independently assessed oral proficiency scores, with the exception of participant 8. We can see, then, that there is a greater match between negative attitudes and oral proficiency than between positive attitudes and oral proficiency, which aligns with the quantitative data detailed in chapter 4. Even so, the complexity of the attitudes expressed by the informants in this study shows once again that using

multiple instruments to gather data about attitudes is a sound methodological choice, as Cherciov (2012) recommends.

5.3 The extremes

In this section I present a global analysis of the informants with the highest and lowest independently assessed oral proficiency levels, taking into account the entire body of data available for each one of them. Table 5.5 shows the four participants with the lowest independent oral proficiency scores, while table 5.6 shows the four participants with the highest independent oral proficiency scores, together with their corresponding data.

Participant	Gender	Proficiency (Independent)	Proficiency (Self-Eval)	Cultural Practice	Positive Attitudes		Negative Attitudes		Trips		BP Parent	Parent College	Pt Course College
#2	F	31	33	27	Total	40	Total	26	VT	No	1	Yes	Yes
					BP	13	BP	6	LT	Yes			
					Bil/Bic	14	Bil/Bic	11	ST	No			
					Immig.	13	Immig.	9					
#3	M	38	44	38	Total	43	Total	16	VT	Yes	1	Yes	Yes
					BP	15	BP	4	LT	Yes			
					Bil/Bic	14	Bil/Bic	5	ST	No			
					Immig.	14	Immig.	7					
#5	M	38	31	25	Total	36	Total	25	VT	Yes	2	No	Yes
					BP	12	BP	8	LT	No			
					Bil/Bic	11	Bil/Bic	7	ST	Yes			
					Immig.	13	Immig.	10					
#18	M	38	28	31	Total	32	Total	24	VT	Yes	1	Yes	Yes
					BP	11	BP	8	LT	No			
					Bil/Bic	12	Bil/Bic	6	ST	No			
					Immig.	9	Immig.	11					

Table 5.5. Low performers data

The first interesting piece of data we see is that, among the informants with the lowest scores, three are male, and one is female, while among the ones with the highest scores the picture is inverted, three are female, and one is male. There is data showing that among college students, females tend to over perform academically

when compared to males in many academic areas, in the US and in several other countries.

According to research, one of the factors impacting this difference is higher motivation levels from females (Kleinfeld, 1999; Buchmann and DiPrete, 2006; Kusurkar et al., 2013). Even if we are not measuring academic achievement in this study, it is possible to speculate that, due to the characteristics of the group of informants, which are all college students, females could have an advantage over males by being more motivated to work on their skills in BP, for instance. Academic instruction in Portuguese in college does not seem to play a role in oral proficiency levels, though, since three out of the four highest performers took a course in Portuguese in college, but so did all informants in the low performers group.

Participant	Gender	Proficiency (Independent)	Proficiency (Self-Eval)	Cultural Practices	Positive Attitudes		Negative Attitudes		Trips		# BP Parent	Parent College	PT Course College
#1	F	52.5	55	40	Total	45	Total	15	VT	Yes	2	Yes	Yes
					BP	15	BP	3	LT	Yes			
					Bil/Bic	15	Bil/Bic	5	ST	No			
					Immig.	15	Immig.	7					
#13	F	52	36	29	Total	43	Total	15	VT	Yes	2	No	No
					BP	15	BP	5	LT	Yes			
					Bil/Bic	14	Bil/Bic	4	ST	No			
					Immig.	14	Immig.	6					
#14	M	53	54	38	Total	41	Total	15	VT	Yes	2	No	Yes
					BP	14	BP	3	LT	Yes			
					Bil/Bic	14	Bil/Bic	6	ST	Yes			
					Immig.	12	Immig.	6					
#19	F	53.5	51	31	Total	45	Total	17	VT	No	2	No	Yes
					BP	15	BP	3	LT	No			
					Bil/Bic	15	Bil/Bic	9	ST	No			
					Immig.	15	Immig.	5					

Table 5.6. High performers data

The results in chapter 4, subsection 4.3.1, had already indicated that trips to Brazil do not correlate with independent oral proficiency scores. Examining the tables, we can see that there is no consistency in the groups regarding this variable. We can see that, for solo trips, which is the kind of trip I had hypothesized could play a more

significant role in oral proficiency levels, since the informant would potentially have to use more BP to communicate, both groups have identical data: three out of four informants in each group did not take such trips, while one did. As for the second kind of trip, long family vacations (over a month), when the informants would potentially have longer exposure to BP, in the low performers group two of the informants took such trips, and the other two did not, while in the high performers group, three informants answered yes, while one answered no. For short family vacations (less than a month), in the low performers group three informants took such trips, while one did not, while in the high performers group three informants took these trips and one did not. Interestingly enough, informant 19, who has the highest independently assessed oral proficiency score in the entire group, has never travelled to Brazil at all.

Another very interesting piece of data is the informants' parents' educational attainment. As we saw in chapter 2, some studies, such as Lambert and Taylor (1996) and MacGregor-Mendoza (2015), find that parental educational attainment and socioeconomic status do play a role in language choice and use in heritage speakers, since middle class parents encourage their kids to use both the heritage language and the dominant language, a phenomenon Lambert and Taylor (1996) call additive bilingualism. For my participants' levels of oral proficiency in BP, however, the picture is very different. We can see that in the low performers group, three of the informants have at least one parent with a college degree, while one does not. In the high performers group, only one of the informants has at least one parent with a college degree, while the other three do not. Informant 19, who is the highest performer, does not have any parent with a college degree. If we link her parents' relatively low educational attainment with a lack of proficiency in English, we can speculate that she might have had more interaction in BP with her parents than other informants. In fact, we know from the background questionnaire data that both her parents were born in Brazil. One studied until the equivalent to eleventh grade in US, and arrived

in the US at age 28. The other arrived in the US at age 31, and studied until the equivalent of fifth grade in the US. It does not seem to be a great stretch to assume that both parents may have limited proficiency in English. We also know from the background questionnaire that informant 19 spoke BP at home as a child. These data indicate that participant 19 has had access to a lot of input in BP at home during childhood, and as a solid body of research in heritage language acquisition has already proved, input plays a critical role in heritage language acquisition, (Montrul, 2008a; Polinsky, 2008; Benmamoun et al., 2010; Montrul and Polinsky, 2011). Participants 13 and 14 have similar profiles, so we can apply the same hypothesis to both of them. In the case of participant 13, both her parents were also born in Brazil. One of them has the equivalent of a high school degree in the US, and arrived here at age 22. The other parent has the equivalent of a sixth grade education in the US, and arrived in the country at age 29. Participant 13 also reports speaking Portuguese at home as a child. Participant 14's parents were born in Brazil, and studied until the equivalent of eighth and fifth grade in the US, arriving in the country at age 22 and 20, respectively. Participant 14 also reports speaking Portuguese at home as a child. For these participants, it can be hypothesized that their parents' low educational attainment, and probable low proficient level in English, gave them more access to input in BP during childhood, which could have contributed to their high oral proficiency scores.

Still related to the role of input in acquisition, the findings detailed in chapter 4, subsection 4.3.4, show a statistically significant correlation between informants' independently accessed oral proficiency levels and having one or two parents who are native speakers of BP. When we look at tables 5.5 and 5.6, we can see that in the high performers group, all have two parents who are native speakers of BP. In the low performers group, on the other hand, only one informant has two parents who are native speakers of BP, while the other three have only one. Besides that, among the high performers group, all participants indicated that they spoke only BP at home

as children, while among the low performers' group, all four participants indicated speaking both BP and English at home as children. This data again is in line with research conducted in the field of heritage language acquisition for several decades, showing the importance of input in the heritage language during early childhood for acquisition.

In terms of cultural practices, we can see in tables 5.5 and 5.6 that, although there is some consistency in the low performers group, in the sense that all of them have low cultural practices scores, there is no consistency in the high performers group. One of them, participant 1, has a high cultural practices score, while the other three do not. In fact, participant 19, the highest performer, has a cultural practices score of 31 out of 45, the same score as participant 18, who is in the low performers group. However, she did have experiences in her childhood that could be described as cultural practices, but were not captured in the cultural practices questionnaire. In the oral interview, when asked about her relationship with Brazil, the Brazilian culture and BP, participant 19 said: "I have never travelled to Brazil, so I don't know exactly how Brazil is, but the culture, because I grew up in a church with many Brazilians, I think it was easier to keep in touch with Brazilian culture, because it wasn't just my parents, there were other people too. I thank God that I had my church's people, because it really helped me (keep in touch with Brazilian culture)." Participant 1 also mentions the church as fundamental for her knowledge of BP: "My parents were members of a church where everyone was Brazilian, there were about 500 Brazilians. All my friends were Brazilian, and spoke only Portuguese. (...) I didn't even know there was an 'American' world." These two informants' experiences show once again, as it was mentioned in chapter 4, that maybe the kinds of cultural practices measured by the questionnaire in this study are not the ones that can actually result in higher exposure to the heritage language and culture, and studies that deal with this variable may have to operationalize and measure cultural practices in different terms.

Regarding positive attitudes, we can see that, even if I did not find a statistically significant correlation between positive attitudes scores and independent oral proficiency scores, two of the participants in the high performers group (1 and 19) have positive attitudes scores of 45/45, and the other two (13 and 14) have positive attitudes scores above 40 (43 and 41, respectively). In the low performers group, however, the lowest performer (2), has a relatively high positive attitudes score (40/45), although she mentions in the interview that she does not like to speak Portuguese in public: “I don’t like (to speak Portuguese in public). It’s not my strongest language, and I’m afraid (of speaking Portuguese in public). I’m also a very shy person. I don’t like to speak Portuguese, but I want to like it, that’s why I’m studying it, to get more comfortable.” As we can see, she expresses mixed feelings. On one hand she is afraid of speaking Portuguese in public, but on the other hand she wants to improve her knowledge of Portuguese. Once again, we see the importance of the interview to reveal subtleties that the questionnaire is not able to capture.

Participant 3 also has a high positive attitudes score, and as we saw in section 5.1, in the interview he describes his efforts to improve his Portuguese and his pride of being Brazilian. Again, these positive attitudes do not automatically translate into a high oral proficiency score. The other two participants in the low performers group have lower positive attitudes scores.

In terms of the positive attitudes per topic, we can see that in the low performers group, the distribution of positive attitudes is relatively uniform, except for participant 18, who has significantly lower positive attitudes in relation to immigration in comparison with the other two topics. We have already seen in section 5.2 that in the interview participant 18 makes clear distinctions between legal and illegal immigration, and has strong negative attitudes about illegal immigration. In the high performers group, the positive attitudes per topic are more equally distributed, without any dramatic differences in the scores per topic.

In terms of negative attitudes, it is interesting to see that participant 3, despite being in the low performers group, has a low negative attitudes score. We have already seen in section 5.1 that he reported in the interview that he makes consistent efforts to improve his knowledge of BP, and that he believes his current knowledge of BP has already helped him in his academic life, when he was writing his college application essay. Among the low performers, he has the lowest overall negative attitudes score, and the lowest negative attitudes score for BP specifically. Participant 2, besides having the highest overall negative attitudes score in the group, has also the highest negative attitudes score towards BP.

It is also interesting to see that, in the low performers group, three out of the four informants have an overall negative attitudes score over 20, while in the high performers one, none of the informants has a negative attitudes score over 20. Also notable is the fact that in the high performers group, three of the informants (1, 13, and 14) have the lowest overall negative attitudes score for the entire group (15). Besides, three of the four (1, 14, and 19) have the lowest possible negative attitudes scores for BP. In the low performers group, the negative attitudes scores for BP are higher (6, 4, 8, and 8). As for negative attitudes about immigration, despite the fact that it is generally the topic drawing more negative attitudes in both groups, we can see that they are much higher in the low performers group (9, 7, 10, and 11, respectively), than in the high performers group (7, 6, 6, and 5, respectively).

These data show us that both groups are more uniform in terms of positive attitudes, and show more variation in terms of negative, as it is also true for the entire group of informants.

CHAPTER 6

CONCLUSION

The main goal of this study was to look into possible correlations between the oral proficiency of heritage speakers of Brazilian Portuguese and their attitudes towards their heritage language, bilingualism and biculturalism, and immigration in the US. I also looked into a possible correlation between cultural practices and oral proficiency within the same population.

There have been several studies that looked into correlations between attitudes and language maintenance and use in heritage speaker populations, but not many studies dealt with potential correlations between language attitudes and proficiency in these groups. Isolating language proficiency as a variable in attitudes studies can provide important information about the roles that stakeholders and the society at large play in a minority language that is being transmitted to future generations. For some time now, scholars and practitioners have been pursuing ways to improve heritage language instruction, and much has been written about heritage speakers' specific characteristics. However, we know very little about how language attitudes can influence the communicative ability of heritage speakers, and in turn the everyday practice of educators who are working with this population. Is there something that teachers and parents can do attitude-wise to encourage heritage language learning? Are some everyday attitudes preventing or discouraging heritage speakers from becoming more proficient and thus being able to use their heritage language in different contexts, including professional ones? To answer these and other relevant questions

about attitudes and language proficiency, we need more studies in the area, proposing novel ways to operationalize each variable and to explore potential correlations.

This study analyzed positive and negative attitudes separately, and found that higher negative attitudes scores correlate with lower oral proficiency scores in the group of informants analyzed. On the other hand, there was no statistically significant correlation between positive attitudes scores and oral proficiency. This methodological choice helped me explore the potential impact of different types of attitudes in the quality of oral language production in a heritage population. Such findings open up doors for new lines of inquiry and, at the same time, further inform ways in which questions about attitudes and language proficiency can be formulated.

Another important finding is the impact of different types of negative attitudes on oral proficiency, even when these attitudes are not directed towards the heritage language itself. By controlling for statements dealing with three different topic areas, I could show that this group of participants displays practically no negative attitudes towards *Brazilian Portuguese*. In fact, their negative attitudes towards bilingualism and biculturalism, and especially towards immigration, are significantly more pronounced. These results show something particular to this population and I do not necessarily expect them to hold for other languages, or for heritage speakers of BP in other contexts. Nevertheless, it is interesting to see that even when heritage speakers do not have particularly strong negative attitudes towards their heritage languages, other topics related to their social status may still impact their proficiency. The results also show that it is important to carefully define the topics in the attitudes data collection instruments, since different topic areas may elicit different attitudes.

Another contribution of this study can be seen in the way *oral proficiency* was operationalized. By using a functional rubric that measures the participants' ability to perform specific communicative tasks, I eliminate contested evaluative metrics that rely more heavily on grammatical accuracy or vocabulary repertoire. Assessment in-

struments that are more structurally defined are commonly used in second language instruction. However, there is an ongoing debate around the appropriateness of their use in the case of heritage speaker populations, primarily because such instruments could yield higher scores for heritage speakers who had formal education in their heritage language or who speak a prestige variety, to the detriment of heritage speakers who do not have these characteristics. By using a functional scale, I was able to evaluate my informants' communicative ability in their heritage language without running the risk of discriminating against some members of the group.

Given the common practice of having self-assessed scores used in language attitude correlational studies, I decided to verify if the self-assessed versus independently assessed scores could yield different results. Interestingly, for the population in this study, i.e. college students, there seems to be a direct correlation between both evaluative methods. These results point to the possibility that the discrepancy between self-assessment and independent assessment found in other studies may be due to the differences between the assessment instruments used for each evaluation, and not necessarily to an inability of heritage speakers to self-evaluate. However, this debate is far from settled and more research is needed for us to truly understand the nature of divergent results between studies when comparing self-assessment with independent assessment. Due to this ongoing controversy, I opted to use the independently assessed scores to investigate correlations in this study, since they are considered the gold standard in the field of assessment.

While not the main point of this study, I also looked into the correlation between oral proficiency and cultural practices in heritage speakers. While other studies found such correlation, mine did not. Given the many distinct ways in which cultural practices are defined, the discrepancy in the results from different studies clearly point to the need for explicitly discussing the variable operationalization procedures in the field. In this study the cultural practices are measured in relation to the frequency

with which heritage speakers engage in activities that expose them to their heritage culture, which could possibly lead to higher exposure to the heritage language, which could in turn result into higher levels of oral proficiency. Other studies operationalize this variable in terms of identification with statements that measure heritage speakers' feelings towards their heritage culture. Here the debate is also not settled and further research is needed to advance the research on cultural practices. Another important issue researchers need to debate is which kinds of cultural practices could lead to higher exposure to the heritage language.

Another important methodological contribution of this study was the use of two different data collection instruments for attitudes, a questionnaire and an oral interview. As Cherciov (2012) mentions, studies that use only one of these instruments sometimes find contradictory data, and the best methodological approach is to use both. As we saw in chapter 5, many times the interview clarifies data gathered through the questionnaires, and it also helps show subtleties in the informants' attitudes that are not easily captured by questionnaires.

Finally, another important contribution of this study is that it examines heritage speakers of Brazilian Portuguese. As we saw in chapter 1, Brazilians are a significant group of immigrants in the US, and in New England, where most of our participants are from and where all of them chose to study, Portuguese (Brazilian, European, and Capeverdean) is the third most spoken language, after English and Spanish. We need more studies about Portuguese speakers in the US, and this dissertation contributes to fill this void.

6.1 Limitations of this study

As with all scientific inquiries, this study also presents some limitations that need to be discussed in order for us to ask new research questions and advance the field. One important limitation involves the configuration of the group of informants. As

we saw in chapter 3, all our participants are college students. This limits our ability to extrapolate the results to other groups of heritage speakers with lower educational levels. Perhaps, if we conducted this exact same study with a group of informants who did not have access to a college education, the results could be different, since we know that educational attainment is a variable that impacts several areas of a person's life, including the ones represented in the main variables of this study, i.e. attitudes towards the heritage language and oral proficiency.

Another important limitation concerns the kinds of data I was able to collect when using a questionnaire and a single interview. As we saw in subsection 4.3.4, I found that, for our participants, having one parent who is a native speaker of Brazilian Portuguese versus having two native speakers parents has a statistically significant correlation to their oral proficiency scores. This finding is in line with previous studies that show the importance of input in the heritage language for the acquisition process. However, with the instruments available in this study I do not have a way of evaluating the amount of input in the heritage language our participants receive from their parents or in their households.

For the topic of the impact of cultural practices on heritage language proficiency, questionnaires and a single interview also seem to be insufficient. In this case, ethnographic studies would probably be the most appropriate methodological approach, since observations of the community of which the informants are members would offer the best opportunities to observe their cultural and linguistic practices.

6.2 Future work

This dissertation's findings point to several open avenues of investigation, which could be addressed by future research. The first one is to repeat this study with a group of adult informants that do not have a college degree, to investigate the impact of educational attainment in variables related to attitudes and oral proficiency in the

heritage language. Another possible expansion would be to collect the same type of data with heritage speakers of different languages, and investigate the distribution of positive and negative attitudes by topic area. The hypothesis here is that speakers of different heritage languages can have different attitudes in relation to their heritage languages in particular, and it would be interesting to look into the impact of these potential differences on their oral proficiency scores.

Moreover, there are general topics that need to be further discussed and possibly reconceptualized in future studies. One example is the way in which the variable attitudes was operationalized in this study by dividing it into three topic areas. Future research could probe into the nature of these areas and propose new topics that should be considered and evaluated. There is an infinite number of topics that could have some impact on language transmission and proficiency.

One final element that needs to be considered is the possible correlation between language proficiency and language maintenance. As we saw, some studies focus on the impact of attitudes in language maintenance and others in language proficiency, but further work needs to be done to understand how these two variables could be correlated. This is particularly important in minority communities where language use is limited to internal family dynamics. Heritage languages have a better chance of being passed on to future generations if they are perceived as languages that can function in different communicative scenarios with uses that go beyond the household, as Mejías et al. (2003) indicate. These possible extended uses are directly related to how well speakers can use their heritage language for multiple communicative functions, i.e., to language proficiency.

In sum, this study gives one more step into the exploring complex linguistic and social dynamics within heritage populations in the US. There is still much to be done for us to better understand the roles that attitudes can play in heritage language proficiency and transmission. More studies will need to be done with other languages,

in different linguistic contexts, and with other groups of participants. I hope that the results and the methodological discussions presented here will inspire future work in the area, expanding the dialog about attitudes and broadening our perspectives on such relevant topics.

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APPENDIX

SOCIODEMOGRAPHIC QUESTIONNAIRE

Please tell us more about yourself. Circle or complete in writing (when applicable) the requested information below.

1. Background information

a. Self:

1. Gender: Male Female Other
2. Age: _____
3. Born in the U.S.? yes no
If born in another country, name of the country: _____
4. If not born in the U.S., age of arrival in the U.S.: _____
5. Number of years living in the U.S.: _____
6. Hometown: _____ Years living in hometown: _____
7. Age at which you started to learn **English**:
 - a. At birth.
 - b. Childhood. Age: _____
 - c. Adolescence. Age: _____
 - d. Adulthood. Age: _____
8. Age at which you started to learn **Portuguese**:
 - a. At birth.
 - b. Childhood. Age: _____
 - c. Adolescence. Age: _____
 - d. Adulthood. Age: _____

b. Parent 1:

1. Gender: Male Female Other
2. Born in the U.S.? yes no
 - a. If born in another country, name of country: _____
 - b. If not born in the U.S., age of arrival in U.S.: _____
 - c. Number of years living in the U.S.: _____
3. Language spoken with his/her parents **as a child**: _____
4. Language spoken with his/her parents **as an adult**: _____
5. Highest academic degree obtained: _____
6. Occupation in the country of origin (before arrival in the U.S., if s/he was not born here):

7. Current occupation in the United States: _____

c. Parent 2:

1. Gender: Male Female Other
2. Born in the U.S.? yes no
 - a. If born in another country, name of country: _____
 - b. If not born in the U.S., age of arrival in U.S.: _____
 - c. Number of years living in the U.S.: _____
3. Language spoken with his/her parents **as a child**: _____
4. Language spoken with his/her parents **as an adult**: _____
5. Highest academic degree obtained: _____
6. Occupation in the country of origin (before arrival in the U.S., if s/he was not born here):

7. Current occupation in the United States: _____

d. Grandparents:

- a. Birthplace of grandparents on parent 1 side: (Country)

- b. Birthplace of grandparents on parent 2 side: (Country)

2. Language Use

a. Language(s) you speak at home **NOW** (choose all that apply):

- a. English
- b. Portuguese
- c. Other(s) (Explain)

b. Language(s) you spoke at home **AS A CHILD** (choose all that apply):

- a. English
- b. Portuguese
- c. Other(s) (Explain)

c. Picture yourself hanging out with each of the 3 friends that you have most contact with **NOW**. Which language are you speaking? (choose all that apply):

With friend #1:

1. English
 2. Portuguese
 3. Other(s) (Explain)
-

With friend #2:

1. English
 2. Portuguese
 3. Other(s) (Explain)
-

With friend #3:

1. English
 2. Portuguese
 3. Other(s) (Explain)
-

d. Now picture yourself playing with each of the 3 friends that you used to have most contact with **AS A CHILD**. Which language are you speaking? (choose all that apply):

With friend #1:

4. English
 5. Portuguese
 6. Other(s) (Explain)
-

With friend #2:

4. English
 5. Portuguese
 6. Other(s) (Explain)
-

With friend #3:

4. English
 5. Portuguese
 6. Other(s) (Explain)
-

e. Language(s) you speak **AT WORK** (choose all that apply):

- a. English
- b. Portuguese
- c. Other(s) (Explain)

f. Language(s) you speak in public when you are with your family (choose all that apply):

- a. English
- b. Portuguese
- c. Other(s) (Explain)

3. Trips to Brazil

a. Family vacation trips.

Yes No

If you answered yes, when and for how long:

b. Long trips (more than one month)

Yes No

If you answered yes, when and for how long:

c. Trips that included going to school in Brazil

Yes No

If you answered yes, when and for how long:

d. Solo trips (without the relatives with whom you live in the US)

Yes No

If you answered yes, when and for how long:

4. Language proficiency

a. Current language communicative ability.

I can communicate with Portuguese speakers:

1. Not at all
2. Poorly
3. Reasonably well
4. Well
5. Very well

b. Previous studies in Portuguese:

a. Bilingual program in Elementary School. In which grade levels:

b. Middle/High School Portuguese. Number of years:

c. College/University level. Please specify courses:

c. Knowledge of Languages other than Portuguese or English:

a. Yes. Language(s):

b. No.

c. If you answered yes, did you learn the other language(s) formally (in a class)? For how many years?

OBRIGADA!

Questionnaire 1 - Please rate **the frequency** with which you do the following things using the scale below:

1. Never 2. Rarely 3. Sometimes 4. Often 5. Very frequently

1. I eat Brazilian food.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

2. I listen to Brazilian music.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

3. I watch Brazilian movies and/or TV shows.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

4. I read Internet websites in Portuguese.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

5. I keep up with current events in Brazil through Internet sites and/or Brazilian TV.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

6. I keep in touch with my family and friends through social networks and/or text messages in Portuguese.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

7. I speak Portuguese with my Brazilian and/or Brazilian-American friends.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

8. My family and I keep at least some Brazilian cultural habits and traditions.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

9. I travel to Brazil during vacations.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

Questionnaire 2 - Please rate **your degree of agreement** with the following statements using the scale below:

1.Strongly disagree 2. Disagree 3. Neither agree nor disagree 4. Agree 5. Strongly agree

1. So far, I do not think knowing Portuguese has brought me many benefits or advantages.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

2. Immigrants should not have the same rights and benefits as US-born citizens.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

3. Portuguese is a beautiful language.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

4. Immigrants make important contributions to their communities in the US.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

5. Being bicultural and bilingual is in many aspects an advantage to me.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

6. It is easier for a monolingual English speaker to be more successful than a person who speaks another language besides English in the US.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

7. Being a child of immigrants has made my life in the US harder than the lives of my friends who are not children of immigrants.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

8. Speaking another language had or can have a negative impact on my ability to speak English well.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

9. Being a child of immigrants and being bilingual and bicultural make my life richer.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

10. I am proud of my ability to speak Portuguese and of my Brazilian heritage.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

11. It is better to speak only English with my family when we are in public spaces.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

12. Knowing Portuguese helps me or will help me in the future with my professional life.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

13. Immigration creates more problems and conflicts in the US than benefits to the country.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

14. The energy and time necessary to keep my Portuguese knowledge are too great, and the benefits of knowing it too small.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

15. All immigrant parents should teach their native language to their US-born children.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

16. It is not crucial for me to learn Portuguese or maintain my Portuguese knowledge because live in the U.S.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

17. A person loses an important part of their identity when they do not have contact with their parents' language and culture.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

18. Immigration is a positive thing, and it has always been what defines the US as a country.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

Questionnaire 3 - Please rate **your ability** do the following things **in Portuguese**. Use the following scale:

1. Not at all 2. Poorly 3. Reasonably well 4. Well 5. Very well

1. I can describe myself, my family and my friends.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

2. I can describe my typical day at work or school.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

3. I can describe images of people performing different activities.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

4. I can talk about my last vacation, for example, describing things that I did, places I visited, etc.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

5. I can discuss the advantages and disadvantages of two opposing options. For instance: working from home vs. working in an office.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

6. I can talk about a nice trip that I took.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

7. I can talk about how I imagine my life and the world in the future.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

8. I can formulate hypotheses. For instance, what I would do if I were the president of the US.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

9. I can give advice to a friend. For instance, to someone who is having family problems.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

10. I can talk about what I would have done if I were in the place of somebody who had a problem. For instance, a student who forgot to turn in a paper before the deadline.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

11. I can talk about abstract topics. For instance, vegetarianism or veganism vs. more traditional diets.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

Oral Interview Questions

1. Me fale um pouco sobre você e a sua família. (Tell me about yourself and your family).
2. Como é a sua rotina em um dia típico de trabalho (ou estudo)? (How is your typical day at work or school?)
3. Descreva as pessoas nesta foto. O que elas estão fazendo? (Describe the people in this picture. What are they doing?)
4. O que você fez nas suas últimas férias? (What did you do on your last vacation?)
5. Na sua opinião, é melhor morar em uma cidade grande ou em uma cidade pequena? Por quê? (In your opinion, is it better to live in a big city or in a small town? Why?)
6. Imagine que você ganhou 50 milhões de dólares na loteria. O que você faria? (Imagine you won 50 million dollars in the lottery. What would you do with the money?)
7. Fale sobre alguma viagem ou passeio interessante que você fez. (Tell me about an important trip or outing in your life.)
8. Imagine a sua vida e o mundo daqui a 20 anos. Como você acha que vai ser? (Imagine your life and the world in 20 years. How do you think it's going to be?)
9. Imagina que um amigo ou amiga está tendo problemas com o namorado ou namorada e te pede ajuda. Que conselhos você vai dar para ele ou ela? (Imagine a friend of yours is having problems with their significant other, and asks for your advice. What kind of advice would you give them?)

10. Imagine-se no lugar dessas pessoas. Isso aconteceu ontem com elas. O que você teria feito? (Imagine you were in these people's place. This happened to them yesterday. What would you have done?)
11. Me fala um pouco sobre a sua relação com o Brasil, a cultura brasileira e a língua portuguesa. (Tell me about your relationship with Brazil, Brazilian culture, and Portuguese.)
12. Você tem contato com outros brasileiros na sua cidade de origem? Como é essa comunidade? (Do you have contact with other Brazilians in your place of origin here? How is this community?)
13. Como você se sente falando português em público? O que você acha que as pessoas a seu redor estão pensando? (How do you feel when you speak Portuguese in public? What do you think the people around you are thinking?)
14. Qual é a sua opinião sobre a situação atual dos imigrantes nos EUA? (What is your opinion about the current situation of immigrants in the US?)

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Pictures - question 10





Grader's independent assessment scale: Please rate the participant's ability do the following things in Portuguese. Use the following scale:

1. Not at all 2. Poorly 3. Reasonably well 4. Well 5. Very well

1. The participant can describe themselves, their family and friends.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

2. The participant can describe their typical day at work or school.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

3. The participant can describe images of people performing different activities.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

4. The participant can talk about their last vacation, for example, describing things that they did, places they visited, etc.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

5. The participant can discuss the advantages and disadvantages of two opposing options. For instance: working from home vs. working in an office, or living in a big city vs. living in a small town.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

6. The participant can talk about a nice trip they took.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

7. The participant can talk about how they imagine their life and the world in the future.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

8. The participant can formulate hypotheses. For instance, what they would do if they were the president of the US, or what they would do if they won 50 million dollars in the lottery.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

9. The participant can give advice to a friend. For instance, to someone who is having family problems or problems in their romantic relationship.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

10. The participant can talk about what they would have done if they were in the place of somebody who had a problem. For instance, a student who forgot to turn in a paper before the deadline.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.

11. The participant can talk about abstract topics. For instance, vegetarianism or veganism vs. more traditional diets, or the immigration issue in the US.

1. 2. 3. 4. 5.